

NOMINALIZING CLASSIFIERS AND THE LIMITS OF DOMINANCE: A FIRST LOOK AT A'INGAE'S SYNTACTICALLY BLOCKED MORPHOPHONOLOGY

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ABSTRACT This paper presents and analyzes data from A'ingae (or Cofán, an Amazonian isolate, iso 639-3: con), where the patterns of stress and glottalization in words with classifying nominalizers are sensitive to the base's morphological and syntactic structure. Normally, classifying suffixes override their base's stress and glottalization. However, the overriding is blocked if the base has previously undergone a functional projection spell-out. These A'ingae data show that information about the morphosyntax of the base (specifically, the distinction between functional and categorizing phase heads; e. g. Guekguezian, 2021; Newell, 2008) is accessible and can be referred to in the course of phonological evaluation, thus setting a lower bound on the amount of morphosyntactic information phonology needs to access. Consequently, the study bears on the architecture of the phonology-morphosyntax interface, and contributes to a growing body of literature demonstrating that morphosyntactic information is preserved after Phonological Form (PF) operations such as vocabulary insertion (Gribanova and Harizanov, 2017; Winchester, 2017) and even phonological evaluation (Dobler et al., 2011; Sande, Clem, and Dąbkowski, t.a.).

1 INTRODUCTION

A'ingae (or Cofán, an Amazonian isolate, iso 639-3: con) has a complex system of morphologically mediated phonological interactions between metrical stress and glottal stops. Previous work (mostly focused on the morphophonology of inflected verbs) has shown that the surface position of stress and glottalization depends on the phonological properties of the base and phonological properties of the attached suffixes, as well as idiosyncratic morphological features of the suffixes (e. g. Dąbkowski, 2021b, 2024b, 2025d).

This paper focuses on phonological patterns in (inflected) verbs subordinated with classifying nominalizers. Metrical stress and glottalization in such structures depend on the phonological form of the nominalizer (in line with previous descriptions and analyses, e. g. by Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d), but they also show sensitivity to the morphological and syntactic properties of the base to which the nominalizer attaches. The latter type of interaction is novel and has not been previously identified in the literature on A'ingae.

The example below illustrates this with a near-minimal pair (1). Metrical stress and a glottal stop introduced in an earlier cycle can be deleted by the bounded space classifier $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$ ¹ when the classifier attaches to a bare verbal root, such as $pánʔjen$ ‘turn off’ (1a). (The destressed output is then assigned penultimate “default” stress.) However, stress and glottal stops are always preserved in a phonologically similar base ($páʔje$ ‘be dying’) if it contains an inflectional morpheme, such as the imperfective $-ʔje^{\emptyset}_{\text{IPFV}}$ (1b). Stress is marked with the acute accent (´). Stressed syllables critical for the analysis are additionally given in **boldface**. Suffixes are accompanied by diacritics ($-sfx_{\text{O}}$, $-sfx^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$, $-sfx_{\text{O}}$, $-sfx^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$) which indicate their morphophonological class (to be discussed in Section 3).

(1) INFLECTIONAL MORPHOLOGY BLOCKING STRESS/? OVERWRITING

a. STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

/ **pánʔjen** /
 / [**pánʔjen**]_{vP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ /
 / [**panjenkhû**]_{nP} /
 [**panjénkhû**]_{NP}
 turn off -BND
 “turning-off room”
 (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

b. STRESS/? RETAINED

/ **pa** /
 / [**pa**]_{vP} $-ʔje^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ /
 / [**páʔje**]_{AspP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ /
 / [**páʔjekhû**]_{nP} /
 [**páʔjekhû**]_{NP}
 die -IPFV -BND
 “room where (s/he) is dying”
 (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

The main generalization that will emerge from the present investigation is that the classifying suffixes cannot delete phonological structure (specifically, stress and glottalization) from their base if the base has previously undergone phonological evaluation in the course of a functional projection spell-out. This *condition on dominance blocking* is restated in (2).

(2) CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING

The dominant phonological operation ordinarily triggered by classifying suffixes (the deletion of the stress and glottalization of their base, if extant) is blocked if the base has undergone phonological evaluation in the course of a functional (non-categorizing) projection spell-out.

The implications of the study stem from the above condition, which bears on the architecture of the phonology-morphosyntax interface. By having phonology reference the

1 The following glossing abbreviations have been used: 1 = first person, 2 = second person, 3 = third person, ACC = accusative, ACC2 = accusative 2, ADD = additive focus, ADN = adnominal, ADV = adverbializer, AIMP = attenuated imperative, ANA = anaphora, AND = andative, ANG = angular, ANIM = animate, APPR = apprehensional, ASSR = assertive, BND = bounded, BRS = bristly, CAUS = causative, CNTR = contrastive topic, DCS = deceased, DS = different subject, EXCL = exclusive focus, FLAT = flat, FRST = frustrative, IF = conditional, IMP = imperative, INF = infinitive, INGR = ingressive, IPFV = imperfective, IRR = irrealis, ITER = iterative, LAT = lateral, LOC = locative, LQD = liquid, LRG = large, N = nominalizer, NEG = negative, NEW = new topic, PASS = passive, PATH = path, PERM = permissive, PL = plural, PLC = place, PLS = plural subject, PROH = prohibitive, RCPR = reciprocal, RND = round, RPRT = reportative, SG = singular, SLV = sliver, SS = same subject, T = tense, TENT = tentative, VDM = verbal diminutive, VEN = venitive, VPR = viperous, YNQ = polar interrogative.

morphological/syntactic structure of the base of affixation, the condition violates the principle of grammatical modularity, which is a hypothesis stating that sound (phonology), meaning (semantics), and structure (syntax) each form separate modules of the grammar, do not have direct access to information from the other modules, and cannot interpret their representational apparatus (see e. g. Chomsky, 1965, 1966; Chomsky and Halle, 1968; Sadock, 2012; Scheer, 2012; Zwicky and Pullum, 1986; and references in Lasnik and Lohndal, 2010; Smith, 2005). The principle of grammatical modularity is restated in (3).

(3) PRINCIPLE OF GRAMMATICAL MODULARITY

(drawing on Chomsky, 1965, 1966; Sadock, 2012; and others)

Sound (phonology), meaning (semantics), and structure (syntax) each form separate modules of the grammar, which do not have direct access to information from the other modules and cannot interpret their representational apparatus.

In the proposed analysis, the classifiers' overwriting of stress and glottalization is blocked by spell-out associated with "high" inflectional, but not "low" derivational, suffixes, which will be formalized as a distinction between *functional* phase heads and *categorizing* phase heads (e. g. Guekguezian, 2021; Newell, 2008). This distinction is referenced by the condition on phonological dominance, which shows that at least some morphosyntactic information (from the structure module) needs to be accessed by phonology (the sound module).

In doing so, the account contributes to a growing body of literature demonstrating that morphosyntactic information is preserved (and accessible) after PF operations such as, for example, linearization (Fox and Pesetsky, 2005), vocabulary insertion (Gribanova and Harizanov, 2017; Winchester, 2017), and even phonological evaluation (Dobler et al., 2011; Sande, Clem, and Dąbkowski, t.a.) and prosodification (Branan, 2018).

The rest of the paper is structured as follows. Section 2 gives background on the language and its speakers. Section 3 summarizes previous findings on verbal morphology. Section 4 describes the patterns of stress and glottalization observed in forms suffixed with classifying nominalizers. Section 5 outlines an analysis by relating these patterns to conditions on phonological spell-out. Section 6 presents and rejects alternative proposals. Section 7 discusses the findings and concludes.

2 LANGUAGE BACKGROUND

A'ingae (or Cofán, iso 639-3: con) is an Amazonian isolate spoken in northeast Ecuador and southern Colombia. The language is endangered and highly underresourced. The Cofán people have experienced severe ecological and economic duress. Nevertheless, their attitudes towards their language and cultural heritage are uniformly positive, and they welcome projects aimed at bolstering the language's status (Dąbkowski, 2021a).

A'ingae is a heavily agglutinating, exclusively suffixing (and encliticizing), and predominantly head-marking language. The word order is flexible, but largely SOV, especially in

subordinate clauses, which will be the focus of this paper. The language's syllable structure is (C)V(V)(?), i. e. onsets are optional, nuclei are maximally diphthongal, and the glottal stop is the only possible coda. VV diphthongal nuclei are the only heavy nuclei in the language; there are no long monophthongs. In this paper, I use the language's practical orthography, with one exception: the glottal stop is transcribed as ʔ, rather than an apostrophe ('). Postvocalic *m* and *n* are not codas—they represent vowel nasality, as well as consonantal prenasalization if followed by a stop. A'ingae shows progressive nasalization, leading to extensive oral-nasal allomorphy among its many functional morphemes (Dąbkowski, 2024a; Fischer and Hengeveld, 2023; Sanker and AnderBois, 2024).

The role that syntactic structure plays in blocking the A'ingae morphophonological effects—which is the main focus of the paper—will be demonstrated with patterns of stress assignment and glottalization. A'ingae stress is culminative and obligatory at the level of the phonological word. The position of stress is contrastive (4). The presence of glottalization is contrastive in roots (5a-b) and affixes (5c-d). The position of the glottalization is contrastive in morphologically complex forms (5e-f).

- (4) CONTRASTIVE STRESS (Dąbkowski, 2021b, p. 612)
- | | | | |
|---------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------------|---|
| a. <i>népi</i> -ye _○ | b. <i>nepí</i> -ye _○ | c. <i>áfa</i> -ye _○ | d. <i>afá</i> -ye _○ ⁰ |
| disappear -INF | arrive -INF | speak -INF | speak -PASS |
- (5) CONTRASTIVE GLOTTALIZATION (Dąbkowski, 2024b, p. 438)
- | | | | | | |
|-------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------|---------------------------------|----------------------------------|---|
| a. <i>chá̃ndi</i> | b. <i>cháʔndi</i> | c. <i>tsá</i> =ma _○ | d. <i>tsá</i> -ʔma _○ | e. <i>séʔje</i> -pa _○ | f. <i>séje</i> -ʔpa _○ ⁰ |
| be clear | be cold | ANA =ACC | ANA -FRST | cure -SS | cure -N |

Basic descriptive facts of A'ingae are covered in Fischer and Hengeveld's (2023) grammatical sketch. Previous work on A'ingae morphology, syntax, and semantics includes e. g. AnderBois, Altshuler, and Silva (2023), Dąbkowski (2023b), Dąbkowski and AnderBois (2024), Fischer and van Lier (2011), Kalpande (2024), and Zheng and AnderBois (2023). Previous work on the A'ingae sound system includes phonetic studies (Bennett et al., t.a. Brandt, 2024; Repetti-Ludlow et al., 2019) as well as descriptions and analyses of various aspects of the language's phonology (Borman, 1962; Dąbkowski, 2023d, 2024a, 2025a,c; Repetti-Ludlow, 2021; Sanker and AnderBois, 2024). A'ingae metrical stress and glottalization participate in a number of morphosyntactically conditioned phonological processes, and have received extensive treatment in Dąbkowski (2021b, 2023a, 2024b, 2025d). The present paper takes Dąbkowski's findings as a point of departure and investigates the morphophonology of A'ingae stress and glottalization in morphologically complex words with classifiers.

All the data that does not come from previous publications has been collected by the author since 2021 with two native speakers from the communities of Dureno and Sinangoé in the province of Sucumbíos, Ecuador. All the fieldwork data has been deposited in the California Language Archive (CLA) as Dąbkowski (2020). Most fieldwork data points are cited with a YYYY-MM-DD(N)_ccc identifier.

3 SUMMARY OF VERBAL MORPHOLOGY

In this section, I summarize the basics of A'ingae verbal inflection, including a brief overview of the verbal morpheme-specific phonological processes. Finite tensed verbs may consist of a bare verbal root, or may be inflected with some of the language's many suffixes, which can be grouped into four phasal domains: *vP*, *AspP*, *TP*, and *CP* (6). There is phonological, morphological, and syntactic evidence diagnosing each of the domains, and each domain may undergo a separate phonological evaluation (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d). The full morphological template of the A'ingae verb is given in Table 1. The root is at the bottom; each successive morphological slot is higher up in the table, mimicking the orientation of a syntactic tree.

(6) AT MOST FOUR PHONOLOGICAL EVALUATIONS PER VERB

[[[[[*kufi* -*án*_○]_{vP} -*ʔjen*_○ -*ngi*_○]_{AspP} -*ʔfa*_○ -*mbi*_○]_{TP} -*ni*_○ -*nda*_○]_{CP}
 play -CAUS -IPFV -VEN -PLS -NEG -IF.DS -NEW

“now_{NEW}, if_{IF} (they_{PLS}) do not_{NEG} come_{VEN} to be_{IPFV} making_{CAUS} play, (someone else_{DS}) ...” (2024-06-18(1)_mll)

The *vP* projection contains the verb root and the causative suffix -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS, if present. The causative -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS is the only verbal suffix capable not only of attaching to verbs (7a), but also of deriving new verbs from nouns, both morphologically simple (7b) and previously derived (7c-d). As such, I follow Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d) in treating -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS as categorizing verbal head *v*.

(7) CAUSATIVE -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS AS A CATEGORIZING *v* HEAD

a. *séma* -*en*_○ b. *tsáuʔ* -*ña*_○ c. *tsáu* -*ʔpa*_○ -*en*_○ d. *tûmbi* -*án*_○ -*khi*_○ -*an*_○
 work -CAUS house -CAUS house -N -CAUS cool -CAUS -BND -CAUS
 “employed” “built a house” “built a nest” “cast a shadow”

The aspectual projection *AspP* contains the other voice suffixes (including the reciprocal -*khu*_○ RCPR and passive -*ye*_○ PASS),² the aspectual suffixes (including the imperfective -*je*_○ IPFV, ingressive -*ji*_○ INGR, verbal diminutive -*kha*_○ VDM, and iterative -*ñaakha*_○ ITER), as well as the associated motion suffixes (including the venitive -*ngi*_○ VEN and the andative -*nga*_○ AND).

The tense projection (*TP*) contains the plural subject -*ʔfa*_○ PLS, irrealis -*ya*_○ IRR, infinitive -*ye*_○ INF, negative -*mbi*_○ NEG, and negative adverbial -*mbe*_○ ADV.NEG. Although A'ingae does

2 In Table 1, the causative -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS is represented as a phase head because there is phonological evidence that *vP* undergoes spell-out. In other descriptions of A'ingae morphology (e.g. Dąbkowski, 2025b,d), the causative -*ña*/*-an*/*-en*_○ CAUS, the reciprocal -*khu*_○ RCPR, and the passive -*ye*_○ PASS are shown together as forming a voice projection (VceP). However, there is no positive evidence that VceP undergoes phonological evaluation. As such, for simplicity, Table 1 does not show a phase boundary above the passive -*ye*_○ PASS, and -*khu*_○ RCPR and -*ye*_○ PASS are lumped together as undergoing spell-out with the aspectual and associated motion suffixes. (Nevertheless, adding a cycle of phonological account between VceP and *AspP* would not change the predictions of the account.)

CP

- (xv) SUBJECT PERSON: $\text{-ngi}_\circ 1$, $\text{-ki}_\circ 2$, $\text{-tsu}_\circ 3$
 (xiv) SENTENCE-LEVEL: $\text{-te}_\circ$ RPRT, $\text{-ti}_\circ$ YNQ
 (xiii) TOPIC: $\text{-ta}_\circ$ NEW, $\text{-ja}_\circ$ CNTR
 (xii) ADDITIVITY: $\text{-?khe}_\circ$ ADD
 (xi) EXCLUSIVITY: $\text{-yi}_\circ$ EXCL
 (x) CLAUSE TYPE
 MATRIX: $\text{-ja}_\circ$ IMP, $\text{-kha}_\circ^\emptyset$ AIMP, $\text{-?se}_\circ$ PERM, $\text{-jama}_\circ^\emptyset$ PROH, $\text{-?ya}_\circ$ ASSR
 COSUBORDINATE: $\text{-pa}_\circ$ SS, $\text{-si}_\circ$ DS
 SUBORDINATE: $\text{-sa?ne}_\circ$ APPR, $\text{-khen}_\circ^\emptyset$ TENT, $(\text{-?a}_\circ \text{ IF.SS,})$ $\text{-?ni}_\circ$ IF.DS, $\text{-?ma}_\circ$ FRST

TP

- (ix) TENSE: $(\text{-?}_\circ \text{ T})$
 (viii) POLARITY: $\text{-mbi}_\circ$ NEG, $\text{-mbe}_\circ$ ADV.NEG
 (vii) REALITY/FINITENESS: $\text{-ya}_\circ$ IRR, $\text{-ye}_\circ$ INF
 (vi) SUBJECT NUMBER: $\text{-?fa}_\circ$ PLS

AspP

- (v) ASSOC MOTION: $\text{-?ngi}_\circ^\emptyset$ VEN, $\text{-?nga}_\circ^\emptyset$ AND
 (iv) ASPECT: $\text{-?je}_\circ^\emptyset$ IPFV, $\text{-ji}_\circ$ INGR, $\text{-kha}_\circ^\emptyset$ VDM, $\text{-?ñakha}_\circ^\emptyset$ ITER
 (iii) PASSIVE: $\text{-ye}_\circ^\emptyset$ PASS
 (ii) RECIPROCAL: $\text{-khu}_\circ^\emptyset$ RCPR

vP

- (i) CAUSATIVE: $\text{-ña/-an/-en}_\circ$ CAUS
 (o) VERBAL ROOT: $\checkmark$

Table 1: Morphophonological template of the A'ingae verb (building on Dąbkowski, 2025b,d,e)

not have any over morphological tense marking, the tense head itself (T) is phonologically realized as $\text{-?}_\circ$ when immediately followed by an information structural morpheme. (For further discussion and analysis, see Dąbkowski, 2025b.)

The complementizer projection (CP) contains various clause-level and sentence-level exponents. Since the A'ingae clauses discussed in Section 4.2 cannot contain verbal structure above TP, I will not discuss the CP suffixes (and clitics) in detail.

In Table 1, the arcs represent phasal domains which may undergo spell-out, or phonological evaluation. Solid arcs represent phases that always undergo phonological evaluation (if present). Dashed arcs represent phases that undergo phonological evaluation only under

certain morphosyntactic conditions (to be discussed throughout the paper and summarized in [Section 5](#)).

3.1 Morpheme-specific phonology

Now, I turn to the basic morphophonological processes affecting A'ingae verbs discussed in previous literature (e. g. Dąbkowski, 2021b, 2024b, 2025d). First, there are three phonological classes of roots: stressless, stressed, and glottalized (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d). Stressless roots have no underlying stress. On the surface, stress is assigned to the penultimate syllable (8a-b). This can be seen as the stress shifts when a recessive suffix is added (9a-b). Stressed roots have underlying stress on the first syllable (8c). The stress of stressed roots does not shift when a recessive suffix is added (9c). Glottalized roots have a glottal stop in the rime of the penultimate syllable, and all of them are also stressed (8d-e). As such, their stress does not shift upon suffixation (9d-e).

(8) STRESSLESS ROOTS		STRESSED ROOT	GLOTTALIZED ROOTS	
a. / <i>afe</i> / [<i>áfe</i>] give	b. / <i>atapa</i> / [<i>atápa</i>] breed	c. / <i>káti</i> / [<i>káti</i>] cast	d. / <i>íʔna</i> / [<i>íʔna</i>] cry	e. / <i>ákheʔpa</i> / [<i>ákheʔpa</i>] forget
(9) ... WITH A SUFFIX		... WITH A SFX	... WITH A SUFFIX	
a. / <i>afe</i> -ji _⊙ / [<i>aféji</i>] give -INGR	b. / <i>atapa</i> -ji _⊙ / [<i>atapáji</i>] breed -INGR	c. / <i>káti</i> -ji _⊙ / [<i>kátiji</i>] cast -INGR	d. / <i>íʔna</i> -ji _⊙ / [<i>íʔnajin</i>] cry -INGR	e. / <i>ákheʔpa</i> -ji _⊙ / [<i>ákheʔpaji</i>] forget -INGR

Additionally, there are at least four morphophonological classes of A'ingae suffixes: *inner recessive*, *inner dominant*, *outer recessive*, and *outer dominant*. The labels *inner* and *outer* reflect the fact that the inner suffixes are typically closest to the root, followed by the outer suffixes. The *recessive* suffixes preserve the stress and glottalization of their base of attachment. The *dominant* suffixes delete the base's stress (and if *inner*, also glottalization).

A detailed analysis of A'ingae verbal morphophonology, couched in Cophonologies by Phase (Sande, Jenks, and Inkelas, 2020), is given in Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d). Below, the phonological processes triggered by the suffix classes are given as descriptive algorithms. First, the *inner recessive* suffixes (10) retain the stress and glottalization of their base (11d-f). If the base is stressless, they do not assign any stress themselves. Instead, penultimate stress is assigned by “default” (11a-c). (In [Section 5](#), the “default” stress assignment will be analyzed at taking place at TP spell-out.) The inner recessive suffixes are marked with a subscripted circled dot (-sfx_⊙).

- (10) INNER RECESSIVE (-sfx_⊙) STRESS RULE
- Retain base stress and glottalization (if any).
 - Do not assign new stress. (Eventually, penultimate stress is assigned to stressless outputs.)

(11) APPLICATIONS OF THE INNER RECESSIVE STRESS RULE

- | | | |
|--|--|---|
| a. / <i>afe</i> -an _○ /
[<i>áfian</i>]
give -CAUS | b. / <i>athûi</i> -ji _○ /
[<i>athûiji</i>]
spit -INGR | c. / <i>atapa</i> -ji _○ /
[<i>atapáji</i>]
breed -INGR |
| d. / <i>áfase</i> -an _○ /
[<i>áfasian</i>]
offend -CAUS | e. / <i>káʔni</i> -ji _○ /
[<i>káʔnijin</i>]
enter -INGR | f. / <i>áʔmbian</i> -ji _○ /
[<i>áʔmbianjin</i>]
have -INGR |

The *inner dominant* suffixes (12) delete the stress and glottalization of their base. If the inner dominant suffix does not have a glottal stop, the output is stressless, and later receives the “default” penultimate stress (13b-d). If the suffix has a glottal stop, stress is assigned to the syllable which has the second mora to the left of the glottal stop (if the base has more than one mora). This is to say, if the glottalized syllable contains a diphthong, i. e. is heavy, (or is the first syllable of the word,) the glottalized syllable itself receives stress if it (13e). However, if the glottalized syllable is light, stress is assigned to the syllable that precedes it (13a,f).³ The inner dominant suffixes are marked with a subscripted circled dot and a superscripted empty set (-sfx_○[∅]).

(12) INNER DOMINANT (-sfx_○[∅]) STRESS RULE

- i. Delete base stress and glottalization (if any).
- ii. If the suffix has a glottal stop:
 if the glottalized syllable is heavy (contains a diphthong) or is the first syllable of the word:
 assign stress to the glottalized syllable;
 otherwise:
 assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes the glottalized one.
 Otherwise (i. e. if the suffix does not have a glottal stop):
 do not assign new stress. (Eventually, penultimate stress will be assigned to stressless outputs.)

(13) APPLICATIONS OF THE INNER DOMINANT STRESS RULE

- | | | |
|--|--|--|
| a. / <i>atapa</i> -ʔje _○ [∅] /
[<i>atápaʔje</i>]
breed -IPFV | b. / <i>fûndûi</i> -kha _○ [∅] /
[<i>fûndûikha</i>]
sweep -VDM | c. / <i>áfase</i> -khu _○ [∅] /
[<i>afasékhu</i>]
offend -RCPR |
| d. / <i>áʔjû</i> -ye _○ [∅] /
[<i>ajûye</i>]
vomit -PASS | e. / <i>káʔnian</i> -ʔngi _○ [∅] /
[<i>kaniáʔngi</i>]
insert -VEN | f. / <i>ákheʔpa</i> -ʔñakha _○ [∅] /
[<i>akhépaʔñakha</i>]
forget -ITER |

³ To account for the interaction between glottalization and stress (including stress deletion), Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d) proposes that, within the *inner* domain, (i) glottalization is an optional feature of metrical feet, (ii) A'ingae footing is trochaic, (iii) the glottal stop is preferentially right-aligned with its foot (whenever possible). Since glottal stops are a metrical feature of the foot in the inner domain, stress deletion triggered from within it also deletes glottal stops.

The *outer recessive* suffixes (14) retain preexisting stress and glottalization (15d-f). However, if the base is stressless, they assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes the (first) outer recessive suffix (15a-c). The outer recessive suffixes are marked with a subscripted dotted circle ($-sfx_{\circ}$).

(14) OUTER RECESSIVE ($-sfx_{\circ}$) STRESS RULE

- i. Retain base stress and glottalization (if any).
- ii. If the base is stressless:
assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes the suffix.

(15) APPLICATIONS OF THE OUTER RECESSIVE STRESS RULE

- | | | |
|---|---|--|
| a. / afe $-?fa_{\circ}$ /
[$afé?fa$]
give -PLS | b. / $athûi$ $-ya_{\circ}$ /
[$athûiya$]
spit -IRR | c. / $atapa$ $-sa?ne_{\circ}$ /
[$atapása?ne$]
breed -APPR |
| d. / $áfase$ $-?ma_{\circ}$ /
[$áfase?ma$]
offend -FRST | e. / $á?mbian$ $-si_{\circ}$ /
[$á?mbiansi$]
have -DS | f. / $ákhe?pa$ $-ja_{\circ}$ /
[$ákhe?paja$]
forget -IMP |

Finally, the *outer dominant* suffixes (16) assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes them, regardless of the base type (17a-f). However, the glottal stops of the base remain intact (17c-f). The outer dominant suffixes are marked with a subscripted dotted circle and a superscripted empty set ($-sfx_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$).

(16) OUTER DOMINANT ($-sfx_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$) STRESS RULE

- i. Delete base stress, but retain glottalization (if any).
- ii. Assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes the suffix.

(17) APPLICATIONS OF THE OUTER DOMINANT STRESS RULE

- | | | |
|---|---|---|
| a. / $atapa$ $-khen_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$atapákhen$]
breed -TENT | b. / $áfase$ $-jama_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$afaséjama$]
offend -PROH | c. / $á?jû$ $-kha_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$a?jûkha$]
vomit -AIMP |
| d. / $á?mbian$ $-khen_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$a?mbiánkhen$]
have -TENT | e. / $ákhe?pa$ $-jama_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$akhe?pájama$]
forget -PROH | f. / $ká?ni$ $-?fa_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ $-kha_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ /
[$ka?ni?fákha$]
enter -PLS -AIMP |

The surface stress and glottalization of a verb depend both on the class of the root and the suffixes that attach to it. In morphologically complex verbs, the output form results from a cyclic application of the morphophonological rules. Generally speaking, each step in the presented derivations corresponds to a well-formed word. Two examples of morphologically complex words whose phonological form reflects their derivational history are given in (18).

(18) CYCLIC PHONOLOGY RESULTING IN SURFACE STRESS AND GLOTTALIZATION

- a. / *ákheʔpa* -en_○ / *root is stressed and has a glottal stop*
 / [*ákheʔpaen*]_{vP} -ʔje_○[∅] / *inner recessive -en_○ CAUS preserves stress, glottalization*
 / [*akhepáenʔjen*]_{AspP} -ʔfa_○ / *inner dominant -ʔje_○[∅] IPFV deletes stress/?; prestresses*
 / [*akhepáenʔjenʔfa*]_{TP} -jama_○[∅] / *outer recessive -ʔfa_○ PLS retains previous cycle's stress/?*
 [*akhepaenʔjenʔfájama*]_{CP} *outer dominant -jama_○[∅] PROH retains ?; prestresses*
 forget -CAUS -IPFV -PLS -PROH
 “don't_{PROH} y'all_{PLS} be_{IPFV} making_{CAUS} forget” (2024-08-19(1)_mll)
- b. / *séʔje* / *root is stressed and has a glottal stop*
 / [*séʔje*]_{vP} -ye_○[∅] -ji_○ / *no vP suffixes; the root stress and glottalization are retained*
 / [*sejeyeji*]_{AspP} -mbi_○ / *-ye_○[∅] PASS deletes stress/?; leaves output stressless*
 / [*sejeyejímbi*]_{TP} -ʔma_○ / *outer recessive -mbi_○ NEG assigns stress to preceding syllable*
 [*sejeyejímbiʔma*]_{CP} *outer recessive -ʔma_○ FRST retains the previous cycle's stress*
 cure -PASS -INGR -NEG -FRST
 “is not_{NEG} about_{INGR} to be_{PASS} cured, but_{FRST} ... ” (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

If the output of the morphological derivation is stressless, either because it involves a stressless root or stress has been deleted by an inner dominant suffix, penultimate stress is assigned. While I previously referred to it as the “default” stress, I assume that the penultimate stress assignment takes place specifically in the course of TP spell-out (following Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d) (19).⁴ This assumption is further vindicated in Section 5.

(19) TP-LEVEL PENULTIMATE STRESS ASSIGNMENT

- / *séʔje* / *root is stressed and has a glottal stop*
 / [*séʔje*]_{vP} -ye_○[∅] -ji_○ / *no vP suffixes; the root stress and glottalization are retained*
 / [*sejeyeji*]_{AspP} / *inner dominant -ye_○[∅] PASS deletes stress/?; leaves output stressless*
 [*sejeyeji*]_{TP} *penultimate stress assigned to stressless output at TP*
 cure -PASS -INGR
 “is about_{INGR} to be_{PASS} cured” (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

3.2 Morphology and tensedness

Finally, I briefly discuss the temporal interpretation of A'ingae matrix clauses. Although there is no morphology in A'ingae devoted specifically to the expression of time, tense is determined by a combination of lexical aspect, morphological aspect, and reality marking. For example, eventive verbs without morphological aspect marking are interpreted as past

4 In Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d), the *outer* TP suffixes' prestressing and the TP-level penultimate stress assignment receive a unified analysis. Both are analyzed as a matter of stress alignment with the right edge of AspP (ALIGN(STRESS-R, PHASE-R)), outranked by word-level NONFINALITY(STRESS). In the absence of TP suffixes, the right edge of AspP coincides with the right edge of the phonological word. A violation of NONFINALITY(STRESS) is completely avoided and the gradient ALIGNMENT constraint is violated minimally, resulting in stress on the second syllable counting from the right edge of the prosodic word/AspP.

(20a). To effect a present (continuous) interpretation, the imperfective suffix $-\gamma je^{\emptyset}$ IPFV must be added (20b). This temporal interpretation is not a consequence of an implicature calculated globally over the entire sentence—for example, bare eventive (i. e. past) verbs are incompatible with future adverbs (20c). To allow for a future interpretation, a verb must first combine with the irrealis suffix $-\gamma a^{\circ}$ IRR (20d). I attribute the specific temporal semantics of A'ingae verbs to the presence of the TP layer, despite the absence of overt tense morphology.

(20) TENSEDNESS ARISING FROM LEXICAL AND MORPHOLOGICAL ASPECT

- | | |
|---|--|
| <p>a. $[tise =tsû áfe]_{TP}$
 3SG =3 give
 “S/he gave (something).”
 (2024-08-30(1)_mll)</p> | <p>b. $[tise =tsû áfe-\gamma je]_{TP}$
 3SG =3 give-IPFV
 “S/he is giving (something).”
 (2024-08-30(1)_mll)</p> |
| <p>c. $*[tise =tsû áfe tû'i]_{TP}$
 3SG =3 give tomorrow
 intended: “S/he will give (sth)
 tomorrow.” (2024-08-30(1)_mll)</p> | <p>c. $[tise =tsû áfe-\gamma a tû'i]_{TP}$
 3SG =3 give-IRR tomorrow
 “S/he will give (sth) tomorrow.”
 (2025-08-18(1)_mll)</p> |

4 DESCRIPTION: NOUNS AND CLASSIFIER NOMINALIZATIONS

The core data set of this paper pertains to nominalizations formed with A'ingae classifying suffixes. As such, I first touch briefly on the patterns of stress and glottalization observed in basic nouns, and then summarize the phonological outcomes of attaching classifying nominalizers to words of various syntactic classes.

A'ingae nouns can be classified as plain (i. e. not glottalized) or glottalized. Plain nouns have penultimate stress (21a-c) (which I will assume is assigned late, by analogy with the late assignment of penultimate stress to verbs). In glottalized nouns, the rime of the penult has a glottal stop. If the glottalized noun is disyllabic, stress is assigned to the glottalized syllable (21d). If the glottalized noun is trisyllabic, stress is assigned to the syllable which contains the second mora to the left of the glottal stop (21e-f). Thus, glottalized nouns show the same stress pattern as glottalized verbal roots (8d-e) and verbs with preglottalized *inner dominant* suffixes (13).

(21) STRESS IN NOMINAL ROOTS

- | | | | | | |
|-----------------|--------------------|--------------------|-------------------|--------------------|-------------------|
| a. <i>píndu</i> | b. <i>tsunsína</i> | c. <i>chanáŋge</i> | d. <i>thé?thu</i> | e. <i>bánsa?mu</i> | f. <i>anáe?ma</i> |
| hawk | ear | lowland paca | tooth | balsam | hammock |

4.1 Deverbal and denominal derivatives

In addition to morphologically simple nominal roots (21), A'ingae has a variety of strategies for deriving new nouns. The strategy of present interest involves nominal classifiers (a subset of nominalizing suffixes), which characterize the shape, size, or prominent dimen-

sion (be it spatial or temporal) of the referent. The rich set of classifiers includes, but is not limited to, the viperous $-si^{\emptyset}_{\text{VPR}^5}$ (22a), bounded space $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}^6}$ (22b), flat $-je^{\emptyset}_{\text{FLAT}}$ (22c), large $-jiun^{\emptyset}_{\text{LRG}}$ (22d), angular $-?khu^{\emptyset}_{\text{ANG}}$ (23a), lateral $-?fa^{\emptyset}_{\text{LAT}}$ (23b), place $-?thi^{\emptyset}_{\text{PLC}}$ (23c), and path $-?ki^{\emptyset}_{\text{PATH}}$ (23d) classifiers. The A'ingae classifying suffixes can derive nouns from verbs (22-23a-b) and other nouns (22-23c-d). (For non-productive diachronic exceptions from the patterns described here, see Dąbkowski, 2025c.)

- (22) PLAIN CLASSIFIERS ON VERBAL AND NOMINAL ROOTS
- | | | | |
|--|---|---|--|
| a. / $bûthu -si^{\emptyset}_{\text{VPR}}$ /
[$bûthûsi$]
run -VPR
“Puerto Rican racer” | b. / $káti -khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$ /
[$katíkhû$]
throw -BND
“trash can” | c. / $bú?mbu -je^{\emptyset}_{\text{FLAT}}$ /
[$bumbúje$]
pambil -FLAT
“pambil leaf” | d. / $tá?va -jiun^{\emptyset}_{\text{LRG}}$ /
[$tavájiun$]
cotton -LRG
“silk-cotton tree” |
|--|---|---|--|
- (23) GLOTTALIZED CLASSIFIERS ON VERBAL AND NOMINAL ROOTS
- | | | | |
|---|--|---|---|
| a. / $akhûi -?khu^{\emptyset}_{\text{ANG}}$ /
[$akhûi?khu$]
lever -ANG
“lever” | b. / $áfase -?fa^{\emptyset}_{\text{LAT}}$ /
[$afáse?fa$]
criticize -LAT
“critical paragraph” | c. / $tsándie -?thi^{\emptyset}_{\text{PLC}}$ /
[$tsandié?thi$]
man -PLC
“men’s place” | d. / $tsámpi -?ki^{\emptyset}_{\text{PATH}}$ /
[$tsámpi?ki$]
forest -PATH
“forest trail” |
|---|--|---|---|

Whether attaching to verbal or nominal roots, the classifiers delete the stress and glottalization of the base. If the classifier has a glottal stop, stress is assigned to the syllable that contains the second mora to the left of the glottal stop: The glottalized syllable is stressed if heavy (23a,c); otherwise, the syllable to its left receives stress (23b,d). As such, we see that the nominalizing classifiers are *inner dominant* suffixes. The inner dominant stress rule is repeated below (24).

5 Previous work (e.g. Borman, 1976; Dąbkowski, 2024b; Fischer and Hengeveld, 2023) identifies one variably preglottalized nominalizer $-(?)si$ and glosses it as pertaining to hairy or spiky things. That analysis, however, represents a conflation of two distinct morphemes with different forms and meanings.

The plain (i.e. non-preglottalized) $-si$ is associated with dangerous, snake-like, worm-like, stinging, and/or biting animals, e.g. *kanjánsi* “boa, anaconda,” *apithunúsi* “punisher snake,” *búttúsi* “*Alsophis portoricensis* (Puerto Rican racer),” *kanísi* “hair-thin worm,” *anthanfási* “*Natrix* sp. (water snake),” *khumási* “*Notarius kessleri* (sculptured sea catfish),” *shajási* “centipede,” *shiñúsi* “caterpillar,” *nási* “bee.” As such, I gloss it as $-si^{\emptyset}_{\text{VPR}}$ ‘viperous.’ The preglottalized $-?si$ derives nouns denoting prickly, spiny, spiky, stinging, coarse, or frayed entities (mostly plants), e.g. *ánkhu?si* “nettle,” *núpa?si* “weeds,” *sangánga?si* “leaf used in shamanic healing,” *jú?si* “that bush,” *fúndúsi?si* “broom,” *tshúru?si* “old fabric.” As such, I gloss it as $-?si^{\emptyset}_{\text{BRS}}$ ‘bristly.’

6 The same authors recognize only one (variably preglottalized) nominalizer $-(?)khû$ and call it a “delimited space” classifier. This, again, represents a conflation of two distinct morphemes.

The plain $-khû$ derives nouns that designate various types of delimited or otherwise conceptually bounded spaces, including concave or hollowed-out tools, sections of larger entities, and restricted areas, including plantation types, e.g. *shejechupákhû* “frying pan,” *ethíkhû* “room,” *singékhû* “match,” *thúkhû* “pen,” *setsákhû* “tree stump,” *ambákhû* “yucca plantation,” *mákhû* “which room,” *tsáukhû* “henhouse,” *anajénkhû* “awning,” *anambákhû* “bedroom,” *khupathíkhû* “buttocks.” As such, I gloss it as $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$ ‘bounded’ (space).

The preglottalized $-?khû$ is associated with nouns denoting liquids, e.g. *ácha?khû* “saliva,” *tsá?khû* “water,” *túmba?khû* “sap,” *síngú?khû* “lagoon,” *yú?khû* “broth,” *kúu?khû* “chucula,” *kúndyípa?khû* “urine (m.),” *chhuvípa?khû* “urine (f.),” *únjínfu?khû* “puddle.” As such, I gloss it as $-?khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{LQD}}$ ‘liquid.’

(24) INNER DOMINANT ($-SFX_{\emptyset}$) STRESS RULE

- i. Delete base stress and glottalization (if any).
- ii. If the suffix has a glottal stop:
 - if the glottalized syllable is heavy (contains a diphthong) or is the first syllable of the word:
 - assign stress to the glottalized syllable;
 - otherwise:
 - assign stress to the syllable which immediately precedes the glottalized one.
 - Otherwise (i. e. if the suffix does not have a glottal stop):
 - do not assign new stress. (Eventually, penultimate stress will be assigned to stressless outputs.)

If the classifier does not have a glottal stop, stress is assigned to the penultimate syllable of the word (22). By analogy with stress assignment in the verbal domain (19), I assume that this penultimate stress is assigned in a later cycle following the classifier-triggered stress deletion. I label that cycle NP (as distinct from *nP*), but this label will be immaterial for the analysis. I assume that the NP projection is present for every noun, but NP spell-out preserves preexisting stress and glottalization. Consequently, penultimate stress is only assigned to those nouns whose stress has not been determined by the glottal stop.

Since the classifying nominalizers can form denominal nominalizations, they may attach to nominalized verbs (25a,c) and nominalized nouns (25b). While there is in principle no limit on how many classifiers can attach to one root, forms with more than three nominalizers (25c) are rare. In all words with multiple nominalizers, the surface form reflects a cyclic application of the nominalizers' *inner dominant* morphophonology (followed by the assignment of penultimate stress to classifier-destressed forms; 25c).

(25) CYCLIC STRESS/? OVERWRITING IN DEVERBAL, DENOMINAL NOMINALIZATIONS

a. VERBAL ROOT WITH TWO NOMINALIZERS

/ <i>chhuvi</i> /	verbal root is stressless
/ [<i>chhuvi</i>] _{vP} -ʔpa _∅ /	no vP suffixes; the root remains stressless
/ [<i>chhúviʔpa</i>] _{nP} -ʔkhû _∅ /	-ʔpa _∅ N stresses 2nd syllable to its left; yields "(women's) urine"
/ [<i>chhuvípaʔkhû</i>] _{nP} /	-ʔkhû _∅ LQD deletes ʔ; stresses 2nd syllable to its left
[<i>chhuvípaʔkhû</i>] _{NP}	NP spell-out preserves stress and glottalization
urinate (f.) -N -LQD	
"(women's) urine"	(2024-08-20(1)_mll)

b. NOMINAL ROOT WITH TWO NOMINALIZERS

/ <i>nujan</i> /	nominal roots is stressless, has no ?
/ [<i>nujan</i>] _{NP} -ʔsi ⁰ /	plain nominal root remains stressless
/ [<i>nújanʔsi</i>] _{NP} -ʔfa ⁰ /	-ʔsi ⁰ BRS assigns stress; yields “small plant with thorns”
/ [<i>nújánsiʔfa</i>] _{NP} /	-ʔfa ⁰ FLAT deletes stress/?; output is stressless
[<i>nújánsiʔfa</i>] _{NP}	NP spell-out preserves stress and glottalization
thorn -BRS -LAT	
“thorny vine”	(2024-08-20(1)_mll)

c. VERBAL ROOT WITH THREE NOMINALIZERS

/ <i>sútsa</i> /	verbal root is underlyingly stressed
/ [<i>sútsa</i>] _{vP} -ʔpa ⁰ /	root’s stress is not deleted at vP
/ [<i>sútsaʔpa</i>] _{NP} -ʔkhu ⁰ /	-ʔpa ⁰ N vacuously reassigns stress; yields “sucking”
/ [<i>sútsápaʔkhu</i>] _{NP} -khú ⁰ /	-ʔkhu ⁰ RND deletes ?; reassigns stress; yields “sugar cane”
/ [<i>sútsapakhukhú</i>] _{NP} /	-khú ⁰ BND deletes stress and glottalization; stresses penult
[<i>sútsapakhúkhú</i>] _{NP}	penultimate stress assigned to stressless base at NP spell-out
suck -N -RND -BND	
“sugar cane plantation”	(2024-08-20(1)_mll)

4.2 Subordinate clauses

Besides nominalizing nouns and verbs, some of the A’ingae classifying suffixes can also form subordinate nominalized clauses. Clauses subordinated with the classifiers may be interpreted either as tensed clauses (like the matrix clauses discussed in [Section 3.2](#)), or as entities, such as objects or places, in a way that correlates with their inflectional morphology and/or phonological form. In this section, I will focus on the connection between the form and meaning and propose that the former are TP nominalizations (compatible with TP morphology), and the latter — lower nominalizations (below TP).

4.2.1 Uninflected stressed verbs

First, I consider classifier subordinations of uninflected stressed verbs. If the verb consists of a bare root ([26-28](#)) or has only the derivational causative suffix *-ña/-an/-en*_{CAUS} ([29-30](#)), two outcomes are possible. First, the subordinator may apply its regular phonology and overwrite the stress and glottalization of the base ([26-30a](#)). These nominalizations denote an object or place related to the content of the clause; they are generally translated as nouns or present-tense (generic) clauses. They are compatible with readings where someone is said to, for example, have an object or be the owner of a place (referred to with a deverbal noun), but they have never engaged in the activity denoted by the base of the deverbal derivation (as will be shown below).

Second, the subordinator’s overwriting of stress and glottalization may be blocked ([26-30b](#)). In this case, the underlying stress (and glottalization) of the base end up surfacing unim-

peded. If the subordinated verb is eventive, the nominalization is always interpreted as a past-tense finite clause. Notably, these subordinations cannot receive the generic readings.⁷ They are always understood as predicating a (past) activity of someone. I consider the tensedness of these clauses to indicate that these nominalizations contain the TP layer (despite the fact that A'ingae has no overt TP morphology). In the proposed analysis, there is a structural difference between (26-30a) and (26-30b), which is reflected in both semantics and phonology.⁸

(26) BARE VERB /*KÚNDASE*/ 'TELL' + *-JE*_○ FLAT

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

tíse [*kundasé*]_{VP}-*je*_○ =*ma* =*ngi kán*
3SG tell-FLAT =ACC =1 look

"I read his/her written story." (compatible with: S/he has a written copy, but s/he had not told the story him/herself.) (2024-07-01(3)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

[*tíse* [*kúndase*]_{VP}]_{TP}-*je*_○ =*ma* =*ngi kán*
3SG tell-FLAT =ACC =1 look

"I read his/her written story," i. e. "I read a story that had been told by him/her." literally: "I saw (a) flat (thing) such that s/he (had) told (a story that is written on it)."

not: "*I read his/her written story." (S/he has a written copy, but s/he had not told the story him/herself.) (2024-07-01(3)_mll)

(27) BARE VERB /*KHÁ?YA*/ 'SWIM' + *-?KI*_○ PATH

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

tíse [*kháya*]_{VP}-*?ki*_○ =*ni* =*ngi jáyi*
3SG swim-PATH =LOC =1 going

"I'm going to his/her swimmable river." (compatible with: S/he is the owner of the river, but has never swum before.) (2024-07-01(3)_mll)

7 However, the verbal forms which show stress/glottal overriding, i. e. the forms which I analyze as low nominalizations, can also be translated with past eventive sentences. (I. e., they can be translated in the same way as their high-nominalization counterparts.) For example, in addition to "I'm going his/her shooting range," native speakers accept "I'm going to the room where s/he shot" as a translation of (29a).

I consider such translations to be pragmatically licensed inferences, not literal reflections of the A'ingae sentences' meanings. This is to say, I propose that the literal meaning of *tíse putáen?khú* is close to "his/her shooting room." However, since s/he is the owner of the shooting room, one may infer that s/he most likely shot in it. Hence, the room can be referred to as the "room where s/he shot" (even though that is not what the word literally means). Correspondingly, I maintain that even though tensed translations of sentences such as (29a) are possible, they do not reflect a different amount of syntactic structure.

Most importantly for the analysis presented here, the reverse is not true. I. e., the sentence in (29b) cannot be translated as "*I'm going his/her shooting room" in a context where s/he owns the shooting room, but has never shot a gun him/herself.

8 In A'ingae, both subjects and possessors can be unmarked. As such, although the morphology of the sentence-initial noun phrases (or pronouns) across the example minimal pairs is kept constant, their syntactic roles differ. For example, in (26-30a), *tíse* 3SG is a possessor, but in (26-30b), the same pronoun *tíse* 3SG functions as a subject.

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED⁹

[tíse [kháʔya]_{vP}]_{TP}-ʔki_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG swim-PATH =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to the river where s/he swam.”

not: “*I’m going to his/her swimmable river.” (S/he is the owner of the river, but has never swum before.) (2024-07-01(3)_mll)

(28) BARE VERB /ÁKHUʔSHA/ ‘CHOP WOOD’ + -ʔTHI_○[∅] PLC

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

tíse [akhúsha]_{vP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG chop wood-PLC =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to his/her warehouse where they make firewood.” (compatible with: S/he is the owner of the warehouse, but s/he never chops wood.)

(2024-07-01(3)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

[tíse [ákhusha]_{vP}]_{TP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG chop wood-PLC =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to the spot where s/he chopped wood.”

not: “*I’m going to his/her warehouse where they make firewood.” (S/he is the owner of the warehouse, but s/he never chops wood.) (2024-07-01(3)_mll)

(29) CAUSATIVIZED VERB /PÚʔTA-EN_○/ ‘PIERCE-CAUS’ + -KHŪ_○[∅] BND

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

tíse [putá-en_○]_{vP}-khū_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG pierce-CAUS-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going his/her shooting range.” (compatible with: S/he owns it, but has never shot a gun him/herself.) (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

[tíse [púʔta-en_○]_{vP}]_{TP}-khū_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG pierce-CAUS-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to the room where s/he shot (lit. made (a gun) pierce).”

not: “*I’m going his/her shooting range.” (S/he owns it, but has never shot a gun him/herself.) (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

⁹ Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d) predicts that when a (pre)glottalized inner suffix fails to override the stress of the base, the suffix’s (pre)glottalization should disappear. However, we see that the nominalizers’ (pre)glottalization (as in -ʔki_○[∅] PATH) does not disappear in the cases where the metrical structure of the base is retained. To capture the behavior of the nominalizing suffixes within Dąbkowski’s (2024b, 2025d) Optimality Theoretic model, MAXIMALITY(?) would have to be ranked above FOOT(?) in the *inner dominant* cophology.

- (30) CAUSATIVIZED VERB /**GUÁʔ**THI-AN_○/ ‘BOIL-CAUS’ + -ʔTHI_○[∅] PLC
- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ OVERWRITTEN
 tíse [guá**thi-án**_○]_{vP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG boil-CAUS-PLC =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to his/her boiling place.” (compatible with: S/he has never boiled water him/herself.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED
 [tíse [guáʔ**thi-an**_○]_{vP}]_{TP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG boil-CAUS-PLC =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to the place where s/he boiled (water).”
 not: “*I’m going to his/her boiling place.” (S/he has never boiled water him/herself.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)

The difference between (26-30a) and (26-30b) does not necessarily entail a difference in argument structure. For example, both low (31a) and high (31b) nominalizations are compatible with regular subjects (unmarked) and objects (accusative-marked).

- (31) LOW AND HIGH NOMNLZNS OF /**RÚʔ**NDÁ/ ‘WAIT’ COMPATIBLE WITH CLAUSAL ARGUMENTS
- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ OVERWRITTEN
 máma=me dúʔshû [rú**dá**]_{vP}-khû_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 mom=ACC2 child wait-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to a place where children usually wait for their mothers.” (2024-08-30(1)_mll)
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED
 [máma=me dúʔshû [rúʔ**nda**]_{vP}]_{TP}-khû_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 mom=ACC2 child wait-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to a place where a child waited for his/her mother.”
 not: “*I’m going to a place where children usually wait for their mothers.” (2024-08-30(1)_mll)

4.2.2 Uninflected stressless verbs

Now, I consider uninflected (but optionally causativized) stressless verbs. When a classifier attaches to a stressless verb, low nominalizations apply the regular nominalizer phonology (32-34a). This results in stress on the last syllable of the verb if, for example, the nominalizer is not glottalized (32a), the glottal stop is located in the coda of the nominalizer’s first syllable (33a), or if the last syllable of the verb is heavy (34a).

The high nominalizations (32-34b) show stress on the penultimate syllable of the verb (i. e. second syllable counting from the end of the verbal structure; discounting the nominalizer). In Section 5, I will propose that this verb-penultimate stress is a result of the fact that high nominalizations are TP nominalizations (and TP undergoes phonological evaluation before the attachment of the nominalizer).

- (32) BARE VERB /ATAPA/ ‘REPRODUCE’ + $-KH\hat{U}_{\emptyset}$ BND
- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR $-SFX_{\emptyset}$ STRESS
tíse [atápá]_{vP}-khú_{\emptyset} =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG reproduce-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to his/her (animal) hatchery.” (compatible with: S/he has never had children.) (2024-07-29(1)_mll)
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS
[tíse [atápa]_{vP}]_{TP}-khú_{\emptyset} =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG reproduce-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to the room where s/he reproduced.”
 not: “*I’m going to his/her (animal) hatchery.” (S/he has never had children.) (2024-07-29(1)_mll)
- (33) BARE VERB /PANZA/ ‘HUNT’ + $-FI\hat{N}DI_{\emptyset}$ SLV
- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR $-SFX_{\emptyset}$ STRESS
tíse [panzá]_{vP}-fiṇdi_{\emptyset} =ma =tsû kháṇa-ṛfa
 3SG hunt-slv =ACC =3 steal-PLS
 “They stole his/her (small sliver-like) hunting tool.” (compatible with: S/he had owned it, but s/he never hunted with it before.) (2025-08-19(1)_mll)
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS
[tíse [pánza]_{vP}]_{TP}-fiṇdi_{\emptyset} =ma =tsû kháṇa-ṛfa
 3SG hunt-slv =ACC =3 steal-PLS
 “They stole (the small sliver-like) tool with which she had hunted.”
 not: “*They stole his/her (small sliver-like) hunting tool.” (S/he had owned it, but s/he never hunted with it before.) (2025-08-19(1)_mll)
- (34) CAUSATIVIZED VERB /SAMBA-EN_{\emptyset}/ ‘DRY-CAUS’ + $-\hat{F}A_{\emptyset}$ PLC
- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR $-SFX_{\emptyset}$ STRESS
tíse [sambá-en_{\emptyset}]_{vP}-ṛfa_{\emptyset} =ma =ngi ísû
 3SG dry-CAUS-LAT =ACC =1 take
 “I took his/her siphon.” (compatible with: S/he had never used the siphon.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS
[tíse [sám̐ba-en_{\emptyset}]_{vP}]_{TP}-ṛfa_{\emptyset} =ma =ngi ísû
 3SG dry-CAUS-LAT =ACC =1 take
 “I took (his/her) siphon which s/he had (already) used (to extract water).”
 not: “*I took his/her siphon.” (S/he had never used the siphon.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)

4.2.3 Voice-inflected destressed verbs

The reciprocal $-khu_{\emptyset}$ RCPR and passive $-ye_{\emptyset}$ PASS delete stress and glottalization and leave the output stressless. As such, the reciprocal and passive verbs pattern with the underlyingly

stressless ones. The low nominalizations apply the regular nominalizer phonology (35-37a). The high nominalizations (35-37b) show stress on the penultimate syllable of the verb (where the reciprocal $-khu_{\emptyset}$ RCPR the and passive $-ye_{\emptyset}$ PASS count as part of the verb, but the classifying suffix does not).

(35) DESTRESSED VERB /ÁFA-KHU $_{\emptyset}$ / ‘SPEAK-RCPR’ + -KHŪ $_{\emptyset}$ BND

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR -SFX $_{\emptyset}$ STRESS

tíse [afa-khū $_{\emptyset}$]_{VP}-khū $_{\emptyset}$ =ni =ngi jáyi
3SG speak-RCPR-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to his/her debate room.” (compatible with: The room is newly built; there have been no debates there yet.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS

[*tíse* [afá-khu $_{\emptyset}$]_{VP}]_{TP}-khū $_{\emptyset}$ =ni =ngi jáyi
3SG speak-RCPR-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to the room where s/he debated.”

not: “*I’m going to his/her debate room.” (The room is newly built; there have been no debates there yet.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)

(36) DESTRESSED VERB /ÁFA-KHU $_{\emptyset}$ / ‘SPEAK-RCPR’ + -FI?NDI $_{\emptyset}$ SLV

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR -SFX $_{\emptyset}$ STRESS

tíse [afa-khū $_{\emptyset}$]_{VP}-fi?ndi $_{\emptyset}$ =ma =ngi ísû
3SG speak-RCPR-SLV =ACC =1 take

“I took his/her microphone (lit. small/sliver-like device for debating).” (compatible with: S/he is the owner of the microphone but has never used it.)

(2025-08-19(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS

[*tíse* [afá-khu $_{\emptyset}$]_{VP}]_{TP}-fi?ndi $_{\emptyset}$ =ma =ngi ísû
3SG speak-RCPR-SLV =ACC =1 take

“I took (the) microphone s/he had used for debating.”

not: “*I took his/her microphone.” (S/he is the owner of the microphone but has never used it.) (2025-08-19(1)_mll)

(37) DESTRESSED VERB /SÉ?JE-YE $_{\emptyset}$ / ‘CURE-PASS’ + -JE $_{\emptyset}$ FLAT

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR -SFX $_{\emptyset}$ STRESS

tíse [seje-yé $_{\emptyset}$]_{VP}-je $_{\emptyset}$ =ma =ngi ísû
3SG cure-PASS-FLAT =ACC =1 take

“I took his/her leaf that can cure.” (compatible with: No one was cured with it before.) (2024-08-21(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS

[tíse [sejé-ye_○[∅]]_{vP}]_{TP}-je_○[∅] =ma =ngi ísû
 3SG dry-PASS-FLAT =ACC =1 take

“I took the leaf with which s/he was cured.”

not: “*I took his/her leaf that can cure.” (No one was cured with it before.)

(2024-08-21(1)_mll)

4.2.4 Aspect-inflected stressed verbs

If aspectual morphology, such as the imperfective $-ʔje_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ IPFV, is present on the verb and the inflected verb is stressed (typically as a consequence of morphologically triggered stress assignment), the (otherwise expected) overwriting of stress and glottalization is blocked. Nonetheless, two readings of the subordinated clause are still available. The nominalized clause can denote an object or place where an activity generally takes place (38-39a), or where an activity is taking place at present (38-39b). The former matches the semantics of the low nominalizations we have seen, while the latter corresponds to the regular present-tense reading of matrix imperfective clauses (§3.2). As such, I assume that clauses with perfective $ʔje$ -marked verbs can form both low and high nominalizations, despite the fact that the verb’s stress and glottalization are never overwritten by the nominalizer.

(38) IMPERFECTIVE VERB /ÁNA-ʔJE_○[∅] / ‘SLEEP-IPFV’ + -KHŪ_○[∅] BND

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED

tíse [ána-ʔjen_○[∅]]_{AspP}-khū_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG sleep-IPFV-BND =LOC =1 going

“I am going to his/her bedroom.” (compatible with: S/he is not presently sleeping there.)

(2024-08-23(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED

[tíse [ána-ʔjen_○[∅]]_{AspP}]_{TP}-khū_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG sleep-IPFV-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to the room where s/he is sleeping.”

(2024-08-30(1)_mll)

(39) IMPERFECTIVE CAUSATIVIZED VERB /CHAVA-EN_○-ʔJE_○[∅] / ‘BUY-CAUS-IPFV’ + -ʔTHI_○[∅] PLC

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED

tíse [chavá-en_○-ʔjen_○[∅]]_{AspP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG buy-CAUS-IPFV-PLC =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to his/her store.” (compatible with: S/he’s not selling there right now; I’m going for another reason.)

(2024-08-23(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/ʔ RETAINED

[tíse [chavá-en_○-ʔjen_○[∅]]_{AspP}]_{TP}-ʔthi_○[∅] =ni =ngi jáyi
 3SG buy-CAUS-IPFV-PLC =LOC =1 going

“I am going to the place where s/he is selling.”

(2024-08-30(1)_mll)

4.2.5 TP-inflected stressed verbs

Finally, verbs with overt TP inflection, including the plural subject $-ʔfa_{\circ}$ PLS (40a), the irrealis $-ya_{\circ}$ IRR (41a), and the negative $-mbi_{\circ}$ NEG (42a) always receive tensed interpretations. This is expected, as TP inflection entails the presence of the TP layer. Additionally, when TP suffixes are present, the stress (and glottalization) of the verbal base are retained, regardless of whether they were underlyingly present from the get-go (40a, 42a) or assigned in the course of verbal inflection (41a).

- (40) PLURAL VERB / $rúʔnda-ʔfa_{\circ}$ / ‘WAIT-PLS’ + $-khû_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ BND
 a. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED
 $[tíseʔpa [rúʔnda]_{vP-ʔfa_{\circ}}]_{TP-khû_{\circ}^{\emptyset}} =ni =ngi jáyi$
 3PL wait-PLS-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I am going to the room where they waited.”
 not: “*I’m going to the room where they wait.” (2024-08-23(1)_mll)
- (41) IRREALIS CAUSATIVIZED VERB / $atapa-en_{\circ}-ya_{\circ}$ / ‘BREED-CAUS-IRR’ + $-khû_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ BND
 a. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED
 $[tíse [atapá-en_{\circ}]_{vP-ñá_{\circ}}]_{TP-khû_{\circ}^{\emptyset}} =ni =ngi jáyi$
 3SG reproduce-CAUS-IRR-BND =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to the place where he will breed (animals).” (2024-08-30(1)_mll)
- (42) NEGATED VERB / $panza-mbi_{\circ}$ / ‘HUNT-NEG’ + $-ʔthi_{\circ}^{\emptyset}$ PLC
 a. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED
 $[[kúndase]_{vP-mbi_{\circ}}]_{TP-ʔthi_{\circ}^{\emptyset}-a} =ni =ngi jáyi$
 tell-NEG-PLC-ADN¹⁰ =LOC =1 going
 “I’m going to a place where (s/he) hasn’t told (a story).”
 not: “*I’m going to a place where (they) don’t tell (stories),” “*I’m going to a non-(story-)telling place.” (2024-08-30(1)_mll)

In summary, in low nominalizations of uninflected and voiced-inflected destressed verbs, we see the application of the classifiers’ regular stress/glottal overriding stress and stress assignment. In high nominalizations of uninflected, voiced-inflected destressed verbs, and TP-inflected stressed verbs, as well as all nominalizations of aspect-inflected stressed verbs, we see the preservation of preexisting stress and glottal stop. (If there is no preexisting stress, then stress is assigned to the penultimate syllable of the verbal base.)

5 ANALYSIS: FUNCTIONAL PHASE BLOCKING

I propose that the above patterns can be generalized in the following way: A nominalizing classifier cannot overwrite the stress (and glottalization) of its base if the base has been

¹⁰ The adnominal $-a$ ADN appears on nominalizations of clauses negated with $-mbi$ NEG. The presence of $-a$ ADN does not affect the facts related to stress and glottalization discussed in this paper. For more on the distribution of the negation-triggered $-a$ ADN, see Dąbkowski (2023c).

spelled out as a functional projection. This generalization is restated below as a condition of the A'ingae interface between morphosyntactic structure and phonology (43). (Details of the condition below will be further clarified towards the end of this section.)

(43) **CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING**

The dominant phonological operation ordinarily triggered by classifying suffixes (the deletion of the stress and glottalization of their base, if extant) is blocked if the base has undergone phonological evaluation in the course of a functional (non-categorizing) projection spell-out.

A crucial distinction made by the condition is that between categorizing phrases such as *nP*, *vP*, *advP*, which had been studied largely within the framework of Distributed Morphology (DM) (e.g. Embick, 2010, 2015; Halle and Marantz, 1993; Marantz, 2007; Marvin, 2002), and functional phases such as *AspP*, *TP*, and *CP*, which had been the focus of many syntactic proposals (e.g. Abels, 2003; Chomsky, 2000, 2001, 2004; Svenonius, 2004). (For further discussion of the categorizing–functional phase distinction, see Guekguezian, 2021.) The two groups can be roughly mapped onto derivation and inflection, with the derivational/categorizing morphemes including e.g. nominalizers (*n°*), verbalizers (*v°*), and adverbializers (*adv°*), and the inflectional/functional morphemes including e.g. aspectual (*Asp°*), predicate-level (*T°*), and clause-level (*C°*) information.

Specifically, the spell-out triggered by a categorizing head does not preclude a later change to stress/glottalization triggered by a subsequent morpheme. For example, nouns derived with stacked nominalizers show cyclic overwriting of stress and glottalization; the prevailing surface form is determined by the last morpheme (44). I assume that phases headed by categorizing heads always undergo phonological evaluation, even if the categorizing head itself is phonologically null (such as *v* in the example below). (Additionally, following Bošković 2016, and Dąbkowski 2024b, 2025d for A'ingae, I assume that heads are spelled out together with their complements.)

(44) **CYCLICAL OVERWRITING IN DERIVED NOUNS**

/ sútsa /	verbal root is underlyingly stressed
/ [sútsa] _{vP} -ʔpa [∅] /	root's stress is not deleted at vP
/ [sútsa ʔpa] _{nP} -ʔkhu [∅] /	-ʔpa [∅] _N vacuously reassigns stress; yields “sucking”
/ [sútsa ʔpaʔkhu] _{nP} -khû [∅] /	-ʔkhu [∅] _{RND} deletes ʔ; reassigns stress; yields “sugar cane”
/ [sútsa ʔpaʔkhu] _{nP} /	-khû [∅] _{BND} deletes stress and glottalization; stresses penult
[sútsa ʔpaʔkhu] _{NP}	penultimate stress assigned to stressless base at NP spell-out
suck -N -RND -BND	
“sugar cane plantation”	(2024-08-20(1)_m11)

In nominalized clauses with bare (or causativized) stressed verbs, the surface form depends on the height of nominalization. In low nominalizations, there is no functional projection undergoing spell-out. As such, the classifier overwrites stress and glottalization (45a). I

do not rule out the possibility that other phases, such as VceP or AspP, may be present in the syntactic structure of a subordinated clause. However, I assume that these phases do not undergo phonological evaluation if they do not introduce any overt morphology. As such, I do not represent them in the derivations below.

	WITH: NO OVERT MORPHOLOGY (- $\emptyset$)	OVERT MORPH. (-sfx)
CATEGORIZING PHASES ($nP, vP, \dots$)	✓ undergo spell-out	✓ undergo spell-out
MOST FUNCT. PHASES (VceP, AspP, $\dots$)	✗ do not undergo spell-out	✓ undergo spell-out
TENSE PROJECTION (TP)	✓ undergoes spell-out	✓ undergoes spell-out

Table 2: Conditions on phonological evaluation by phase type and morphological content

I assume that when TP is followed by a nominalizing classifier, TP always undergoes spell-out—even if no overt morphology is realized in TP.¹¹ The conditions on spell-out assumed in the analysis are summarized in Table 2. The spell-out of TP, which is a functional projection, blocks later overwriting. As such, in high (TP) nominalizations, the verb’s underlying stress and glottalization are preserved (45b). In this way, the structural difference between low and high nominalizations finds its reflections in both semantics and phonology.

(45) UNINFLECTED STRESSED VERB

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? OVERWRITTEN

- / *púʔta* -en_○ / *root is underlyingly stressed and glottalized*
 / [*púʔtaen*]_{vP} -khû_○[∅] / *inner recessive -en_○ CAUS does not affect stress/?*
 / [*putaenkhû*]_{nP} / *nominalizer -khû_○[∅] BND applies regular stress/? deletion*
 [*putáenkhû*]_{NP} *penultimate stress is assigned at NP*
 pierce -CAUS -BND
 “shooting room,” “shooting range” (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

- / *púʔta* -en_○ / *root is underlyingly stressed and glottalized*
 / [*púʔtaen*]_{vP} - $\emptyset$ _○ / *inner recessive -en_○ CAUS does not affect stress/?*
 / [*púʔtaen*]_{TP} -khû_○[∅] / *existing stress/? preserved in the course of TP evaluation*
 / [*púʔtaenkhû*]_{nP} / *-khû_○[∅] BND’s stress/? deletion blocked: *[putaenkhû]*
 [*púʔtaenkhû*]_{NP} *preexisting stress/? preserved at NP spell-out*
 pierce -CAUS -T -BND
 “room where (s/he) shot” (2024-08-19(1)_mll)

11 In other syntactic circumstances (not discussed in this paper), e. g. when followed by the verbal CP layer, a phonologically null TP does not undergo spell-out (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d). Thus, I propose that the phonological evaluation/spell-out of a projection may be conditioned not only by its morphological content, but also by its syntactic context. This is similar to Bošković (2014) who argues that phasehood is contextual (although based on purely syntactic criteria, such as extraction availability and ellipsis).

In low nominalizations with stressless verbs, the nominalizer gets to apply its regular stress assignment. For example, if the nominalizer does not have a glottal stop, such as the bounded space $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$, penultimate stress is assigned to the nominalized word (46a). In high nominalizations, penultimate stress is assigned to the verb in the course of TP spell-out. Since TP is a functional projection, the penultimate stress is retained even when the classifier is attached (46b).

(46) UNINFLECTED STRESSLESS VERB

- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR $-SFX^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ STRESS
- | | |
|---|--|
| / atapa / | root is underlyingly stressless |
| / [atapa] _{vP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ / | no overt suffixes in vP; stress not assigned |
| / [atapakhû] _{nP} / | no stress to delete; the output remains stressless |
| [atapákhû] _{NP} | NP spell-out assigns penultimate stress |
| breed -BND | |
| “breeding room,” “hatchery” | (2024-07-29(1)_mll) |
- b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS
- | | |
|---|---|
| / atapa / | root is underlyingly stressless |
| / [atapa] _{vP} $-\emptyset_{\text{O}}$ / | no overt suffixes in vP; stress not assigned |
| / [atápa] _{TP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ / | penultimate stress assigned in the course of TP spell-out |
| / [atápakhû] _{nP} / | $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$ ’s stress/? deletion blocked: *[atapakhû] |
| [atápakhû] _{NP} | NP does not change preexisting stress |
| breed -T -BND | |
| “room where (s/he) reproduced” | (2024-07-29(1)_mll) |

Verbs destressed by the reciprocal $-khu^{\emptyset}_{\text{RCPR}}$ or the passive $-ye^{\emptyset}_{\text{PASS}}$ pattern with the underlyingly stressless ones. First, the inner dominant suffix deletes the stress (and glottalization) of the base (47). Then, in low nominalization, the classifier’s regular phonology is applied (47a). High nominalizations undergo TP spell-out, whereby penultimate stress is assigned to the penultimate syllable. That functional-projection stress is then preserved even after the attachment of a nominalizer (47b).

(47) VOICE-INFLECTED DESTRESSED VERB + PLAIN NOMINALIZER

- a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR $-SFX^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ STRESS
- | | |
|--|--|
| / áfa / | root is underlyingly stressed |
| / [áfa] _{vP} $-khu^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ / | no suffixes in vP |
| / [afakhu] _{AspP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{O}}$ / | stress is deleted by inner dominant $-khu^{\emptyset}_{\text{RCPR}}$ |
| / [afakhukhû] _{nP} / | $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\text{BND}}$ has no stress to delete; stressless output |
| [afakhúkhu] _{NP} | penultimate stress eventually assigned at NP |
| speak -RCPR -BND | |
| “debating room,” “debate room” | (2024-08-21(1)_mll) |

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS

/ áfa /	root is underlyingly stressed
/ [áfa] _{vP} -khu [∅] /	no suffixes in vP
/ [afakhu] _{AspP} -∅ [∅] /	stress is deleted by inner dominant -khu [∅] RCPR
/ [afákhu] _{TP} -khû [∅] /	penultimate stress assigned in the course of TP spell-out
/ [afákhu [∅] khû] _{nP} /	-khû [∅] BND's stress/? deletion blocked: *[afakhukhû]
[afákhu [∅] khû] _{NP}	preexisting stress preserved at NP spell-out
speak -RCPR -T -BND	
“room where (s/he) debated”	(2024-08-21(1)_mll)

When a destressed verb hosts a glottalized nominalizer (48), such as the sliver-shaped classifier *-fi?ndi* SLV (which derives the nouns for small, sliver-, shard-, and/or splinter-like objects), metrical stress is assigned according to the suffix's glottalization in low nominalizations (48a). (In high nominalizations, the spell-out of TP blocks stress overwriting; 48b).

(48) VOICE-INFLECTED DESTRESSED VERB + GLOTTALIZED NOMINALIZER

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — REGULAR -SFX[∅] STRESS

/ áfa /	root is underlyingly stressed
/ [áfa] _{vP} -khu [∅] /	no suffixes in vP
/ [afakhu] _{AspP} -fi?ndi [∅] /	stress is deleted by inner dominant -khu [∅] RCPR
/ [afakhúfi?ndi] _{nP} /	-fi?ndi [∅] SLV stresses 2nd syllable left of ?
[afakhúfi?ndi] _{NP}	NP spell-out retains preexisting stress/?
speak -RCPR -SLV	

“sliver-shaped debating (object),” “small microphone” (2025-08-19(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — VERB-PENULT STRESS

/ áfa /	root is underlyingly stressed
/ [áfa] _{vP} -khu [∅] /	no suffixes in vP
/ [afakhu] _{AspP} -∅ [∅] /	stress is deleted by inner dominant -khu [∅] RCPR
/ [afákhu] _{TP} -fi?ndi [∅] /	penultimate stress assigned in the course of TP spell-out
/ [afákhu [∅] fi?ndi] _{nP} /	-fi?ndi [∅] SLV blocked from assigning stress: *[afakhúfi?ndi]
[afákhu [∅] fi?ndi] _{NP}	preexisting stress preserved at NP spell-out
speak -RCPR -T -SLV	

“small (device with) which (s/he) debated” (2025-08-19(1)_mll)

The pattern seen in (48a) serves as an important clarification on the condition on dominance blocking: The presence of functional projection spell-out blocks the *deletion* of previous metrical structure (and glottal stops) ordinarily triggered by classifying nominalizers. However, previous functional spell-out does not block the classifier-triggered *stress assignment*, which still takes place if no deletion of previous metrical structure is necessary, i. e. if the base is stressless (despite—or because of—an earlier cycle of functional-phase phonological evaluation).

Intuitively, one may think of the blocking as being caused by “functional” metrical structure, where “functional” metrical structure is defined as metrical structure which has undergone phonological evaluation in the course of functional projection spell-out (even if it were first created somewhere earlier in the derivation). A version of the clarified condition on dominance blocking is restated yet again in (49).

(49) CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING (CLARIFIED)

When a nominalizing classifier attaches to a base that

- i. *has undergone phonological evaluation in the course of a functional projection spell-out, and*
- ii. *has metrical structure:*
retain the base’s metrical structure (and glottal stops).

Otherwise:

apply the classifier’s usual inner dominant rule.

Many of the aspectual suffixes delete their base’s glottalization and reassign stress. For example, in imperfective $-ʔje^{\emptyset}_{\circ}$ IPFV assigns stress to the immediately preceding syllable if it is heavy (i. e. a diphthong) (50). I assume that when there is overt morphology present in AspP, the AspP projection undergoes phonological evaluation. Since AspP is a functional projection, it blocks the overwriting of stress even in the absence of the TP layer. As such, stress and glottalization are preserved in both low (50a) and high nominalizations (50b).

(50) ASPECT-INFLECTED STRESSED VERB

a. LOW NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

/ chava -en _○ /	root is underlyingly stressless
/ [chavaen] _{vP} -ʔje [∅] _○ /	inner recessive -en _○ CAUS does not assign stress
/ [chaváenʔjen] _{AspP} -ʔthi [∅] _○ /	inner dominant -je [∅] _○ IPFV stresses preceding heavy syllable
/ [chaváenʔjenʔthi] _{nP} /	-ʔthi [∅] _○ PLC’s overwriting blocked: *[chaváenjenʔthi]
[chaváenʔjenʔthi] _{NP}	preexisting stress/? remain unaltered at NP
buy -CAUS -IPFV -PLC	
“selling place,” “store”	(2024-08-23(1)_mll)

b. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

/ chava -en _○ /	root is underlyingly stressless
/ [chavaen] _{vP} -ʔje [∅] _○ /	inner recessive -en _○ CAUS does not assign stress
/ [chaváenʔjen] _{AspP} -∅ _○ /	inner dominant -je [∅] _○ IPFV stresses preceding heavy syllable
/ [chaváenʔjen] _{TP} -ʔthi [∅] _○ /	previous stress/? preserved at TP evaluation
/ [chaváenʔjenʔthi] _{nP} /	-ʔthi [∅] _○ PLC’s overwriting blocked: *[chaváenjenʔthi]
[chaváenʔjenʔthi] _{NP}	NP does not change preexisting stress/? glottalization
buy -CAUS -IPFV -T -PLC	
“place where (s/he) is selling”	(2024-08-30(1)_mll)

Finally, the presence of TP morphology entails the presence of the TP layer. All the TP affixes assign stress to their bases (some — only if the base is stressless). The spell-out

of TP blocks the classifier's overwriting, so stress and glottalization are always preserved if one (or more) of the TP affixes (the plural subject $-ʔfa_{\circ}$ PLS, the irrealis $-ya_{\circ}$ IRR, or the negative $-mbi_{\circ}$ NEG) is present (51a).

(51) TP-INFLECTED STRESSED VERB

a. HIGH NOMINALIZATION — STRESS/? RETAINED

/ $rúʔnda$ /	<i>root is underlyingly stressed and glottalized</i>
/ [$rúʔnda$] _{vP} $-ʔfa_{\circ}$ /	<i>no suffixes in vP; stress/? retained</i>
/ [$rúʔndaʔfa$] _{TP} $-khû^{\emptyset}_{\circ}$ /	<i>outer recessive $-ʔfa_{\circ}$ PLS does not shift stress</i>
/ [$rúʔndaʔfakhû$] _{nP} /	<i>$-khû^{\emptyset}_{\circ}$ BND's stress/? deletion blocked: *[rundafakhû]</i>
[$rúʔndaʔfakhû$] _{NP}	<i>preexisting stress/? unaffected by NP spell-out</i>
wait -PLS -BND	

“room where (they) waited”

(2024-08-23(1)_mll)

In summary, we have seen that the metrical structure (and glottal stops) which have undergone phonological evaluation in the course of spelling out a functional projection (such as AspP or TP) cannot be overridden by the nominalizing classifiers' dominant phonological rule. Otherwise, i. e. when the base has no metrical structure that has been so “fortified” by the spell-out of a functional projection, classifying suffixes delete the preexisting metrical structure and glottal stops and assign their own stress.

6 REJECTED ALTERNATIVES

The analysis proposed above presents a condition on phonological dominance that (i) is sensitive to a distinction between categorizing and functional phases, (ii) is limited to a particular class of morphemes (nominalizing classifiers), and (iii) references both morphosyntax and phonology, violating the principle of grammatical modularity. Driven by the pursuit of a most parsimonious theory, one might be tempted to try and work out a generalization that captures the facts of Section 4 with the success of Section 5, but without any of the undesirable stipulations implicated in the “condition on phonological dominance.”

In this section, I briefly formulate and discuss three attempts at simplifying or completely overturning the condition. In Section 6.1, I try to reformulate the condition on phonological dominance so that it does not refer to the distinction between categorizing and functional phases (i). In Section 6.2, I ask if the condition may generalize beyond nominalizing classifiers (ii). In Section 6.3, I consider whether the phonological differences between low and high nominalizations may be explained by invoking separate vocabulary items (iii). Ultimately, I will reject the three alternatives as theoretically dubious and/or empirically inaccurate.

6.1 No categorizing phrase spell-out

The condition on phonological dominance (as formulated in [Section 5](#)) refers to the distinction between categorizing phase spell-out and functional phase spell-out: Specifically, the categorizing phase spell-out does not block later stress/glottalization overwriting. Since the categorizing phase spell-out appears phonologically inert, one may consider an alternative analysis where phases headed by categorizing heads do not undergo phonological evaluation at all. This alternative is repeated in [\(52\)](#).

(52) ALTERNATIVE ANALYSIS (TO BE REJECTED)

**Functional phases (VceP, AspP, TP, ...) may undergo phonological evaluation, but categorizing phases (nP, vP, ...) may not.*

If the proposal in [\(52\)](#) were tenable, the condition on phonological dominance could be reduced to saying that the phonological overriding ordinarily triggered by classifying nominalizers is simply blocked by previous spell-out—since categorizing heads do not trigger phonological evaluation, all spell-out is functional projection spell-out, so there is no need to refer to phase types explicitly. The revised condition would refer only to the presence of previous phonological evaluation, not morphosyntactic properties of the base, dispensing with the undesirable cross-module reference. The simplified condition on dominance blocking is given in [\(53\)](#).

(53) *CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING (ALTERNATIVE I, TO BE REJECTED)

When a nominalizing classifier attaches to a base that

i. has undergone phonological evaluation, and

ii. has metrical structure:

retain the base's metrical structure (and glottal stops).

Otherwise:

apply the classifier's usual inner dominant rule.

However, there are reasons to believe that categorizing heads (both *nP* and *vP* discussed in this paper) do undergo phonological evaluation. First, categorizing heads have been cross-linguistically shown to undergo spell-out in Distributed Morphology and related works (e. g. Embick, 2010, 2015; Embick and Marantz, 2008; Embick and Noyer, 2007; Halle and Marantz, 1993; Newell, 2008; Sande, 2020; Sande, Jenks, and Inkelas, 2020). Denying that *nP* and *vP* undergo phonological evaluation would contradict these findings, and demand that we look for new answers to questions already settled in the previous literature.

Second, there is language-internal evidence which suggests that both *nP* and *vP* undergo phonological evaluation. Recall that A'ingae's derived nouns show effects of stress and glottal stop overwriting, which can be captured by the cyclic phonological evaluation of each *nP* layer. If *nPs* did not undergo spell-out, the forms seen at each step of a derivation, e. g. in [\(54\)](#), would be difficult to model.

(54) CYCLICAL OVERWRITING IN DERIVED NOUNS

/ <i>sútsa</i> /	verbal root is underlyingly stressed
/ [<i>sútsa</i>] _{vP} -ʔpa _○ /	root's stress is not deleted at vP
/ [<i>sútsaʔpa</i>] _{nP} -ʔkhu _○ /	-ʔpa _○ N vacuously reassigns stress; yields "sucking"
/ [<i>sútsápaʔkhu</i>] _{nP} -khú _○ /	-ʔkhu _○ RND deletes ʔ; reassigns stress; yields "sugar cane"
/ [<i>sútsapakhukhú</i>] _{nP} /	-khú _○ BND deletes stress and glottalization; stresses penult
[<i>sútsapakhúkhú</i>] _{NP}	penultimate stress assigned to stressless base at NP spell-out
suck -N -RND -BND	
"sugar cane plantation"	(2024-08-20(1)_mll)

Third, the A'ingae vP is an important locus of phonological generalization. Within a vP, glottalization is always realized in the coda of the penultimate syllable. As such, within the vP, the surface position of glottalization is predictable. To capture this fact, Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d) proposes that glottalization in A'ingae verbal roots is underlyingly floating (55), and it is realized in the penultimate coda due to an interaction of demands on phonological well-formedness, including ALIGN(?-R, FOOT-R), which pushes for the glottal stop to surface in the syllable following the stressed syllable, and NONFINALITY(?), which prevents the glottal stop from surfacing word-finally. If vP did not undergo phonological evaluation, this generalization could not be captured.

(55)	POSITION OF ʔ AS PREDICTABLE WITHIN vP		(Dąbkowski, 2024b, pp. 443, 445)
a.	/ seje,ʔ /	b.	/ akhepa,ʔ /
	[séʔje] _{vP}		[ákheʔpa] _{vP}
	cure		forget
		c.	/ akhepa,ʔ-en _○ /
			[ákheʔpaen] _{vP}
			forget -CAUS

Dąbkowski (2024b, 2025d) also extends this account to monosyllabic glottalized roots with underlying diphthongs. Roots of this class show a surface alternation between CVʔV and CVVʔ. The alternation depends on the presence and type of immediately following suffixes. In a bare root (with no overt suffixes present), glottalization surfaces in between the vowels, i.e. CVʔV (56a). If the vP-internal causative suffix -ña_○ CAUS is present, glottalization surfaces after the second component of the diphthong, i.e. CVVʔ (56b). However, if any vP-external suffix follows the root immediately, the glottalization surfaces in between the vowels again, i.e. CVʔV (56c).

(56)	CVʔV–CVVʔ AS vP SPELL-OUT	(Dąbkowski, 2024b, pp. 443–444)			
a.	/ kûi,ʔ /	b.	/ kûi,ʔ -ñã _○ /	c.	/ kûi,ʔ /
	[kûʔi] _{vP}		[kûiʔñã] _{vP}		/ [kûʔi] _{vP} -ji _○ /
					[kûʔiji] _{AspP}
	drink		drink -CAUS		forget -INGR

The patterns of CVʔV–CVVʔ alternation are straightforwardly accounted by assuming that vP undergoes phonological evaluation (Dąbkowski, 2024b, 2025d). If there are no suffixes, the root spells-out by itself. Due to NONFINALITY(?), the glottal stop cannot linearized the

end of the output, so it surfaces between vowels, i. e. CV?V (56a). If the *v*P-internal causative suffix $-ñā_{\ominus}$ CAUS is present, the glottal stop can surface after a diphthong without violating NONFINALITY(?), giving rise to CVV? (56b). Finally, in forms with *v*P-external suffixes, we observe CV?V because those suffixes are attached after NONFINALITY(?) gets to be enforced at *v*P spell-out (56c). If *v*P did not undergo spell out, the CV?V–CVV? alternations observed in A'ingae monosyllabic glottalized roots would be left without an explanation.

In short, there is evidence supporting the phonological evaluation of categorizing phases in A'ingae, including *n*P and *v*P. As such, the simplified analysis of (52–53) is not adopted.

6.2 No restriction to classifiers

Another attempt at simplifying the condition on phonological dominance could involve denying that the blocking is restricted to nominalizing classifiers. Under this proposal, a functional projection spell-out blocks any further alteration to the phonologized material, regardless of the morphosyntactic category of the external dominant suffixes. This idea is restated in (57).

(57) *CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING (ALTERNATIVE II, TO BE REJECTED)

When a dominant suffix attaches to a base that

- i. *has undergone phonological evaluation in the course of a functional projection spell-out, and*
- ii. *has metrical structure:*
retain the base's metrical structure (and glottal stops).

Otherwise:

apply the suffix's usual morphophonological rule.

However, this alternative proposal—at least when stated as generally as in (57)—makes incorrect predictions. As we have already seen in Section 3, the phonological evaluation of a functional projection does not always block later affixes from applying their dominance effects. This is exemplified in (58), where the outer dominant prohibitive $-jama_{\ominus}^{\emptyset}$ PROH reassigns stress to the syllable which precedes it, even though the base has undergone two functional spell-outs (AspP and TP). According to (57), $-jama_{\ominus}^{\emptyset}$ PROH's dominant operation should fail to apply, incorrectly predicting *[*akhepáen?jen?fajama*].

(58) DOMINANCE EFFECTED DESPITE FUNCTIONAL PHRASE SPELL-OUT

/ ákhe?pa -en _⊖ /	root is stressed and has a glottal stop
/ [ákhe?paen] _{vP} -?je _⊖ [∅] /	inner recessive -en _⊖ CAUS preserves stress, glottalization
/ [akhepáen?jen] _{AspP} -?fa _⊖ [∅] /	inner dominant -?je _⊖ [∅] IPFV deletes stress/?; prestresses
/ [akhepáen?jen?fa] _{TP} -jama _⊖ [∅] /	outer recessive -?fa _⊖ PLS retains previous cycle's stress/?
[akhepaen?jen?fájama] _{CP}	outer dominant -jama _⊖ [∅] PROH retains ?; prestresses
forget -CAUS -IPFV -PLS -PROH	
“don't _{PROH} y'all _{PLS} be _{IPFV} making _{CAUS} forget”	(2024-08-19(1)_mll)

By proposing that a functional projection spell-out always blocks later suffixes from applying their morphophonological properties, the simplified condition on dominance blocking undergenerates dominance effects. As such, the alternative analysis of (57) is not adopted.¹²

6.3 Classifier homophony account

Finally, I consider an alternative proposal which accounts for the differences between low and high nominalizations by invoking homophony. Under this analysis, each low-attaching nominalizing classifier has a homophonous high-attaching twin. The two classifiers are associated with different phonological grammars: The low-attaching classifiers are associated with the *inner dominant* cophonology (which overrides stress and glottalization),

¹² This being said, nominal classifiers are not the only category blocked from overriding functionally spelled-out metrical stress and glottalization. While outside the scope of this paper, another set of data where a similar pattern is observed involves modifier clitics on noun phrases.

A'ingae noun phrases can be modified by clitics (i) which alter the stress and glottalization of the base (in ways somewhat similar to the verbal operations discussed in Section 3). For example, the animate plural clitic =ndekhû PL.ANIM (ia) and the deceased honorific clitic =ɣye DCS (ib) both shift stress to the last syllable of their base of attachment (i. e. the syllable which immediately precedes them). However, when stacked, stress reflects the morphophonological operation triggered by the first clitic; the second clitic's rule is blocked from applying (ic). (In the examples below, I use "FP" for "functional projection" without committing to a specific label.)

(i) BLOCKING WITHIN THE NOMINAL DOMAIN

a. NOUN + =NDEKHÛ PL.ANIM

/ yaya /

/ [yaya]_{nP} /

/ [yáya]_{NP} =ndekhû /

[yayánde khû]_{FP}

dad =PL.ANIM

"parents"

underlying stressless nominal root

stress not assigned at nP

penultimate stress assigned at NP

=ndekhû PL.ANIM overrides stress and prestresses

(2025-08-19(1)_mll)

b. NOUN + =ɣYE DCS

/ yaya /

/ [yaya]_{nP} /

/ [yáya]_{NP} =ɣye /

[yayáɣye]_{FP}

dad =DCS

"late father"

underlying stressless nominal root

stress not assigned at nP

penultimate stress assigned at NP

=ɣye DCS overrides stress and prestresses

(2025-08-19(1)_mll)

c. NOUN + =NDEKHÛ PL.ANIM + =ɣYE DCS

/ yaya /

/ [yaya]_{nP} /

/ [yáya]_{NP} =ndekhû /

/ [yayánde khû]_{FP} =ɣye /

/ [yayánde khû ɣye]_{FP}

dad =PL.ANIM =DCS

"late parents"

underlying stressless nominal root

stress not assigned at nP

penultimate stress assigned at NP

=ndekhû PL.ANIM overrides stress and prestresses

=ɣye DCS's overriding blocked by FP spell-out: *[yayandekhûɣye]

(2025-08-19(1)_mll)

Although a full account of morphosyntactically conditioned blocking in cases other than those involving classifying nominalizers is outside the scope of this paper, I include these data to remark that morphosyntactic blocking is not limited to those nominalizers. At the same time, the existence of patterns like (58) shows that blocking is not universally triggered by functional projection spell-out.

while the high-attaching ones are associated with the *inner recessive* cophonology (which retains the preexisting stress and glottalization).

A first attempt at an analysis along these lines is sketched in (59). Each item on the list corresponds to a different vocabulary item (VI), presented in a way which draws on the notational conventions established in DM (e. g. Embick, 2010, 2015; Embick and Marantz, 2008; Embick and Noyer, 2007; Halle and Marantz, 1993) and Cophonologies by Phase (CbP) (Sande, 2017, 2019, 2020; Sande, Jenks, and Inkelas, 2020). The left-hand side of each VI stands for a morphosyntactic feature (bundle), e. g. [BND] or [PLC]. (Additionally, each morpheme’s selectional criteria are stated informally below.) The right-hand side represents the feature (bundle)’s phonological realization, including its segmental content ($\mathfrak{F}$) and cophonological grammar ($\mathfrak{R}$).

(59) *HOMOPHONY ANALYSIS (ATTEMPT I, TO BE REJECTED)

- a. $\begin{array}{l} \text{BND} \\ (\text{selects for: VceP, AspP, TP, ...}) \end{array} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \mathfrak{F} : /-kh\hat{u}/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : \text{inner recessive} \end{array} \right\}$
- b. $\begin{array}{l} \text{BND} \\ (\text{selects for: nP, vP, ...}) \end{array} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \mathfrak{F} : /-kh\hat{u}/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : \text{inner dominant} \end{array} \right\}$
- c. $\begin{array}{l} \text{PLC} \\ (\text{selects for: VceP, AspP, TP, ...}) \end{array} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \mathfrak{F} : /-\eta\theta i/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : \text{inner recessive} \end{array} \right\}$
- d. $\begin{array}{l} \text{PLC} \\ (\text{selects for: nP, vP, ...}) \end{array} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{array}{l} \mathfrak{F} : /-\eta\theta i/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : \text{inner dominant} \end{array} \right\}$
- ...

Under this analysis, the phonological differences between low and high nominalizations are not a result of functional phase-triggered blocking, but simply a consequence of the fact that the low-attaching nominalizers (which select for *nP*, *vP*) are associated with the *inner dominant* cophonology (59b, 59d), while the high-attaching nominalizers (which select for *VceP*, *AspP*, *TP*) are associated with the *inner recessive* cophonology (59a, 59c). (In the example above, the bifurcation between low-attaching and high-attaching versions of homophonous suffixes is exemplified with the bounded space *-khû* BND (59a-b) and place suffix *-ηθi* PLC (59c-d), but it should be understood as holding of all the classifying nominalizers.)

However, this homophony analysis will not be adopted for two reasons. The first problem lies in the statement of the morphemes’ selectional criteria. In the above preliminary attempt, the selectional criteria of the low- and high-attaching suffixes are stated simply as “selects for: *nP*, *vP*, ...” (59b, 59d) and “selects for: *VceP*, *AspP*, *TP*, ...” (59a, 59c), respectively. This differs from Section 5’s condition on dominance blocking (49), as the selectional criteria of (59) refer only to morphosyntactic information—which is in line with the hypothesis of grammatical modularity—but does not capture the condition’s sensitivity to phonologization.

Following standard assumptions (e.g. Chomsky, 1995, 2000; Cinque, 1999; Halle and Marantz, 1993; Kratzer, 1996), I take the verbal spine to consist of a sequence of functional projections, many of which can be morphophonologically unexpressed. As presently stated, the selectional criteria in (59) predict that it is the high-attaching (and phonologically recessive) nominalizers that will be observed any time the base of attachment includes a functional projection, regardless of whether or not that functional projection has introduced any overt morphology and/or undergone phonological evaluation.

For example, recall from Section 4.2.1 that a subordinated verb may combine with both internal and external arguments, regardless of the height of nominalization (60). Assuming that the subject is merged as a specifier to V_{ce}° (Harley, 2013), even the low nominalizations must be analyzed as containing—at minimum—the $V_{ce}P$ layer. Since $V_{ce}P$ is a functional projection, the criteria in (59) predict that a $V_{ce}P$ should be selected by a high nominalizer, even if there is no overt voice morphology and $V_{ce}P$ does not undergo phonological evaluation.

(60) MORPHOLOGICALLY NULL NON-PHONOLOGIZED $V_{ce}P$ /*rúʔnda*/ ‘wait’

a. OVERRIDING CORRECTLY PREDICTED BY THE CONDITION ON DOMINANCE BLOCKING

[*máma=me dúʔshû* [*rundá*]_{VP}]_{V_{ce}P}-*khû*_○ =*ni* =*ngi jáyi*
mom=ACC2 child wait-BND =LOC =1 going

b. BLOCKING INCORRECTLY PREDICTED BY THE HOMOPHONY ANALYSIS

*[*máma=me dúʔshû* [*rúʔnda*]_{VP}]_{V_{ce}P}-*khû*_○ =*ni* =*ngi jáyi*
mom=ACC2 child wait-BND =LOC =1 going

“I’m going to a place where children usually wait for their mothers.”

(2024-08-30(1)_mll)

Under the homophony analysis (59), high nominalizers are associated with the *inner recessive* cophology. As such, the metrical stress and glottalization of the base will not be overridden. In other words, the homophony analysis incorrectly predicts that low nominalizations of $V_{ce}P$ —where stress and glottal stops get overridden—should be impossible (60b). Since the nominalizations which show phonological overriding must be analyzed as containing the $V_{ce}P$ layer, this is a fatal flaw for the (first version of the) homophony analysis. In the example above, a functional projection selected by a high (non-overriding) nominalizer is represented with large solid brackets ([]).

By comparison, the condition on dominance blocking (49) correctly predicts the application of overriding. This is because no new overt morphemes have been introduced in $V_{ce}P$, so $V_{ce}P$ has not undergone phonological evaluation (60a). In the example above, a functional projection which does not undergo phonologization and does not block dominance effects is represented with large dashed brackets ([]).

The discussion so far recapitulates the point that it is not the mere presence of a functional projection—but rather its phonological evaluation—that blocks the overriding of stress/glottalization. In light of this fact, a fix to the homophony analysis could involve stating that the *recessive* nominalizers select for constituents that underwent a functional projection

spell-out, and that the *dominant* nominalizers select for everything else. The second attempt at a homophony analysis is given in (61).

(61) *HOMOPHONY ANALYSIS (ATTEMPT II, TO BE REJECTED)

- a. $\begin{matrix} \text{BND} \\ (\text{selects for: spelled-} \\ \text{out VceP, AspP, TP, ...}) \end{matrix} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{matrix} \mathfrak{F} : & /-kh\hat{u}/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : & \text{inner recessive} \end{matrix} \right\}$
- b. $\begin{matrix} \text{BND} \\ (\text{elsewhere}) \end{matrix} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{matrix} \mathfrak{F} : & /-kh\hat{u}/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : & \text{inner dominant} \end{matrix} \right\}$
- c. $\begin{matrix} \text{PLC} \\ (\text{selects for: spelled-} \\ \text{out VceP, AspP, TP, ...}) \end{matrix} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{matrix} \mathfrak{F} : & /-\mathfrak{?}thi/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : & \text{inner recessive} \end{matrix} \right\}$
- d. $\begin{matrix} \text{PLC} \\ (\text{elsewhere}) \end{matrix} \longleftrightarrow \left\{ \begin{matrix} \mathfrak{F} : & /-\mathfrak{?}thi/ \\ \mathfrak{R} : & \text{inner dominant} \end{matrix} \right\}$
- ...

While the reanalysis sketched out in (61) is not—in principle—inconceivable, and might technically “work” to derive the A’ingae data,¹³ there are three objections to it.

First, we must ask again what would motivate such a reanalysis. If our wish is walk the narrow path of grammatical modularity, the analysis in (61) strays from it, as the selectional criteria of the morphemes in (61a) and (61c) make reference to “spelled-out” constituents. Selectional criteria belong to the morphosyntactic module, and information about spell-out is part of the phonological module. As such, this reanalysis violates grammatical modularity.

Second, the alternative in (61) amounts to proposing that there is a widespread homophony between formally unrelated morphemes in the language, doubling the number of vocabulary items for nominalizing classifiers.¹⁴ Each classifier has a “twin,” which has the same meaning but different selectional criteria, different cophonology, and just *accidentally* happens to have the same segmental phonology. For example, nothing in the reanalysis prevents

¹³ Recall from the condition on dominance blocking (49) that for the overriding of stress and glottalization (normally triggered by nominal classifiers) to be blocked, two requirements have to be fulfilled: (i) the base must have undergone functional projection spell-out, and (ii) the base must be stressed.

The selectional criteria in the homophony analysis (61) mention only the first of those two requirements: The *inner recessive* vocabulary items are selected wherever the base has undergone functional spell-out. At same time, the selectional criteria do not say anything about the base being stressed. As such, under the homophony reanalysis, the *inner recessive* suffixes will be selected even if the base is stressless.

However, since *recessive* cophonologies can assign stress as long as the base of attachment does not have preexisting metrical structure, glottalized *inner recessive* suffixes will still assigns stress to stressless functionally spell-out bases. (Plain *inner recessive* suffixes would not assign stress, but penultimate stress would later be assigned in the next cycle.) As such, the fact that (61a) and (61c) do not explicitly require their bases to have metrical structure does not make incorrect predictions.

¹⁴ Since the A’ingae patterns of blocking go beyond the data described in this paper (see fn. 12), the reanalysis in (61) actually makes the problem of morpheme duplication even more ubiquitous than what the present discussion implies.

a hypothetical A'ingae', which differs from A'ingae in that the low-attaching bound classifier BND is realized as *-khû*, while the high-attaching BND is realized as **-ʔra*. In other words, the analysis in (61) makes it mysterious why segmental content does not covary with a morpheme's dominance.

Third, the reanalysis in (61) misses the relationship between the phonological "strengthening" caused by functional projection spell-out and the blocking of stress/glottal stop deletion. Since the association of each vocabulary item with the *inner recessive* or the *inner dominant* cophonology is just listed in the lexicon, the connection between syntactic structure and phonological dominance blocking is not captured. For example, nothing in the reanalysis prevents low-attaching morphemes from retaining stress and glottalization, or high-attaching morphemes from deleting them (or performing any other arbitrary phonological operation). The condition on dominance blocking (49) connects phonological blocking to the syntactic structure which gives rise to it; the reanalysis (61) makes that connection seem accidental. Consequently, the classifier homophony analysis is not adopted.

7 DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

In summary, I have discussed cases where the A'ingae classifying nominalizers attach to nouns and verbs across a variety of morphosyntactic contexts. The main empirical point of interest has been that the usual phonological process triggered by the classifiers (the deletion of stress and glottalization) is blocked under specific syntactic conditions. This shows that the (morpho)phonological grammar can be—at least to some degree—sensitive to syntactic structure.

Specifically, I have proposed that the stress/glottal overwriting (ordinarily triggered by the classifiers) is blocked when the base of attachment is a phonological word (i. e. has metrical stress) and has undergone phonological evaluation associated with a functional projection. In other words, I have shown that phonology may access the information on whether a suffix's base has undergone spell-out. Additionally, it must be able to distinguish between—at minimum—whether the spelled-out chunk is a categorizing or functional projection.

These findings have important implications for our understanding of (i) the permeability of and interactions between phonology and morphosyntax, (ii) the nature of phasehood and its role in phonology, and (iii) the syntactic structure of clausal nominalizations.

First, the A'ingae data challenge frameworks whose architectural assumptions prevent phonology from accessing the (morpho)syntactic information from previous cycles, including Lexical Morphology and Phonology (Kiparsky, 1982), Stratal Optimality Theory (e. g. Bermúdez-Otero, 1999, 2012; Kiparsky, 2000, 2008), Cophonology Theory (e. g. Anttila, 1997; Inkelas, 1998; Inkelas, Orgun, and Zoll, 1997; Orgun, 1996), Cophonologies by Phase (e. g. Sande, 2017, 2019; Sande and Jenks, 2018; Sande, Jenks, and Inkelas, 2020), and others.

Instead, A'ingae provides evidence that at least some morphosyntactic information is preserved after phonological evaluation. For example, the current account is compatible with

the view that specific morphological features are replaced by phonological content at spell-out, but syntactic labels are retained thereafter. Notably, this assumption is already implicit in DM and related frameworks (Embick, 2010, 2015; Sande, Jenks, and Inkelas, 2020).

More strongly, the A'ingae patterns support approaches where the syntactic information is not only preserved, but also accessible to phonology after spell-out. This includes traditional rule-based architectures where phonological rules can refer to a limited amount of syntactic information (e.g. through bracket labeling in Chomsky and Halle, 1968), Indexed Constraint approaches (e.g. Benua, 1997; Ito and Mester, 1999; Pater, 2009), where phonological constraints can refer to syntactic information (although the amount of syntactic information needed for A'ingae is smaller than what those approaches allow for), as well as an increasing number of modern proposals which allow for varying degrees of permeability between phonology and morphosyntax (e.g. Bošković, 2017; Branagan, 2018; Chen, 2025; d'Alessandro and Scheer, 2015; Dobler et al., 2011; Fox and Pesetsky, 2005; Gribanova and Harizanov, 2017; Martinović, 2019; Newell, 2017; Richards, 2016; Sande, Clem, and Dąbkowski, t.a. Simpson and Wu, 2002; Winchester, 2017).¹⁵

Second, the present findings shed light on the non-uniform nature of phasehood. Broadly speaking, syntactic phrasal models have tended to focus on the phasal nature of functional heads such as C°, D°, and P° (e.g. Chomsky, 2000, 2001). Many morphological models couched within the broad Minimalist Program (Chomsky, 1993, 1995), including Distributed Morphology (e.g. Embick, 2010; Halle and Marantz, 1993; Marantz, 2007) and Nanosyntax (e.g. Caha, 2009; Ramchand, 2008; Starke, 2010), support phase-based derivation of words, but focus on the phasal nature of categorizing heads such as *n*°, *v*°, and *a*° (Guekguezian, 2021).

A small number of studies have compared and contrasted the features of functional and categorizing phases. E.g., Newell (2008) proposes that the two kinds of phase heads have different phonological and morphological properties. Guekguezian (2021) speculates that in Muskogee, *n*°, *v*°, and Asp° may all be phase heads, but *n*° and *v*° show a different

15 Additionally, the present findings resonate strongly with Svenonius's (2024a,b) work on causative morphology at grammatical interfaces. Svenonius proposes a cross-linguistic distinction between *inner causatives* or *outer causatives*, with the two groups differing along several axes. The inner causatives express "direct" causation and are more phonologically irregular/integrated, semantically idiosyncratic, lexically restricted, and syntactically opaque. The outer causatives are often compatible with "indirect causation" and are more independent, productive, transparent, and (phonologically and semantically) regular. Svenonius captures the difference between inner and outer causatives by proposing that the inner causatives are features of Vce° in the same extended projection as the verbal root, while the outer causatives are features of Vce° in a separate extended projection (i.e. words with outer causatives have two Vce-heads). Since each extended projection undergoes spell-out separately, the outer causatives are less integrated with respect to phonology, syntax, semantics, etc. Svenonius's (2024a) proposal can perhaps be extended to shed light on the structural configuration responsible for the condition on dominance blocking (49): The classifiers are not part of the verbal projection, so the verb spells out separately (without the classifier). Assuming that the phonology of a spelled-out projection cannot be altered, the stress/glottal deletion that the classifiers normally trigger is then blocked. Note, however, that only functional projections block the dominance effects. As such, the mechanism proposed by Svenonius cannot be adopted without further refinements.

behavior from Asp^o when it comes to phonology, allomorphy, and allosemy. The present study supports a distinction between functional and categorizing phases, in accord with the previous findings.

Finally, the A'ingae data bear on the syntactic structure of clausal nominalizations. Verbal and nominal spines have traditionally been seen as having parallel structures (e. g. Abney, 1987; Chomsky, 1970; Szabolcsi, 1994). If deverbal nominalizations are mixed extended projections (e. g. Borsley and Kornfilt, 2000), this suggests that there is a trade-off between verbal and nominal structure. For example, nominalizations of large verbal structures (such as TPs) are expected to lack low nominal projections (such as *nP*) (Alexiadou, Iordăchioaia, and Schäfer, 2011; Iordăchioaia, 2020; Iordăchioaia and Soare, 2008).

The present analysis demonstrates that in A'ingae, large verbal structures (AspPs, TPs) can be subordinated with the same heads that also derive regular nouns (*n*^o). This challenges the traditional view, but finds corroboration in Katson (t.a.), who demonstrates that the English *poss-ing* constructions are *nP*-nominalizations of AspPs, and *acc-ing* constructions are *nP*-nominalizations of TPs.

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